

HISTORICAL RECORD
OF THE
53RD FOOT.

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RECORD OF THE FIFTY-THIRD, OR THE SHROPSHIRE REGIMENT
OF FOOT ***

TRANSCRIBER'S NOTE

Some minor changes are noted at the [end of the book](#).

BY COMMAND OF *His late Majesty WILLIAM THE IVth*
and under the Patronage of
Her Majesty the Queen.



HISTORICAL RECORDS,

OF THE

British Army

Comprising the

History of every Regiment,

IN HER MAJESTY'S SERVICE.

By Richard Cannon Esq.^r

Adjutant General's Office, Horse Guards.

London.

Printed by Authority.

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HISTORICAL RECORD
OF
THE FIFTY-THIRD,
OR
THE SHROPSHIRE REGIMENT OF FOOT.
CONTAINING
AN ACCOUNT OF THE FORMATION OF THE REGIMENT
IN 1755
AND OF ITS SUBSEQUENT SERVICES
TO 1848.

COMPILED BY
RICHARD CANNON, Esq.,
ADJUTANT-GENERAL'S OFFICE, HORSE GUARDS.

ILLUSTRATED WITH PLATES.

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THE FIFTY-THIRD,
OR
THE SHROPSHIRE REGIMENT OF FOOT,

BEARS ON THE REGIMENTAL COLOUR

THE WORD "NIEUPORT;"

IN COMMEMORATION OF ITS DISTINGUISHED GALLANTRY IN THE DEFENCE OF THAT FORTRESS IN
OCTOBER, 1793;

THE WORD "TOURNAY;"

IN TESTIMONY OF ITS HEROIC CONDUCT IN ACTION AGAINST A SUPERIOR FORCE OF THE ENEMY IN
MAY, 1794;

THE WORDS "ST. LUCIA;"

AS A MARK OF DISTINCTION FOR ITS BRAVERY DISPLAYED AT THE CAPTURE OF ST. LUCIA, IN MAY,
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THE WORDS

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TO COMMEMORATE THE MERITORIOUS SERVICES OF THE *Second* BATTALION DURING THE PENINSULAR
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THE FIFTY-THIRD,
OR
THE SHROPSHIRE REGIMENT.

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GENERAL ORDERS.

HORSE-GUARDS,

1st January, 1836.

His Majesty has been pleased to command that, with the view of doing the fullest justice to Regiments, as well as to Individuals who have distinguished themselves by their Bravery in Action with the Enemy, an Account of the Services of every Regiment in the British Army shall be published under the superintendence and direction of the Adjutant-General; and that this Account shall contain the following particulars, viz.:—

—— The Period and Circumstances of the Original Formation of the Regiment; The Stations at which it has been from time to time employed; The Battles, Sieges, and other Military Operations in which it has been engaged, particularly specifying any Achievement it may have performed, and the Colours, Trophies, &c., it may have captured from the Enemy.

—— The Names of the Officers, and the number of Non-Commissioned Officers and Privates Killed or Wounded by the Enemy, specifying the place and Date of the Action.

—— The Names of those Officers who, in consideration of their Gallant Services and Meritorious Conduct in Engagements with the Enemy, have been distinguished with Titles, Medals, or other Marks of His Majesty's gracious favour.

—— The Names of all such Officers, Non-Commissioned Officers, and Privates, as may have specially signaled themselves in Action.

And,

—— The Badges and Devices which the Regiment may have been permitted to bear, and the Causes on account of which such Badges or Devices, or any other Marks of Distinction, have been granted.

By Command of the Right Honorable
GENERAL LORD HILL,
Commanding-in-Chief.

JOHN MACDONALD,
Adjutant-General.

PREFACE.

The character and credit of the British Army must chiefly depend upon the zeal and ardour by which all who enter into its service are animated, and consequently it is of the highest importance that any measure calculated to excite the spirit of emulation, by which alone great and gallant actions are achieved, should be adopted.

Nothing can more fully tend to the accomplishment of this desirable object than a full display of the noble deeds with which the Military History of our country abounds. To hold forth these bright examples to the imitation of the youthful soldier, and thus to incite him to emulate the meritorious conduct of those who have preceded him in their honorable career, are among the motives that have given rise to the present publication.

The operations of the British Troops are, indeed, announced in the "London Gazette," from whence they are transferred into the public prints: the achievements of our armies are thus made known at the time of their occurrence, and receive the tribute of praise and admiration to which they are entitled. On extraordinary occasions, the Houses of Parliament have been in the habit of conferring on the Commanders, and the Officers and Troops acting under their orders, expressions of approbation and of thanks for their skill and bravery; and these testimonials, confirmed by the high honour of their Sovereign's approbation, constitute the reward which the soldier most highly prizes.

It has not, however, until late years, been the practice (which appears to have long prevailed in some of the Continental armies) for British Regiments to keep regular records of their services and achievements. Hence some difficulty has been experienced in obtaining, particularly from the old Regiments, an authentic account of their origin and subsequent services.

This defect will now be remedied, in consequence of His Majesty having been pleased to command that every Regiment shall, in future, keep a full

and ample record of its services at home and abroad.

From the materials thus collected, the country will henceforth derive information as to the difficulties and privations which chequer the career of those who embrace the military profession. In Great Britain, where so large a number of persons are devoted to the active concerns of agriculture, manufactures, and commerce, and where these pursuits have, for so long a period, being undisturbed by the *presence of war*, which few other countries have escaped, comparatively little is known of the vicissitudes of active service and of the casualties of climate, to which, even during peace, the British Troops are exposed in every part of the globe, with little or no interval of repose.

In their tranquil enjoyment of the blessings which the country derives from the industry and the enterprise of the agriculturist and the trader, its happy inhabitants may be supposed not often to reflect on the perilous duties of the soldier and the sailor,—on their sufferings,—and on the sacrifice of valuable life, by which so many national benefits are obtained and preserved.

The conduct of the British Troops, their valour, and endurance, have shone conspicuously under great and trying difficulties; and their character has been established in Continental warfare by the irresistible spirit with which they have effected debarkations in spite of the most formidable opposition, and by the gallantry and steadiness with which they have maintained their advantages against superior numbers.

In the official Reports made by the respective Commanders, ample justice has generally been done to the gallant exertions of the Corps employed; but the details of their services and of acts of individual bravery can only be fully given in the Annals of the various Regiments.

These Records are now preparing for publication, under his Majesty's special authority, by Mr. RICHARD CANNON, Principal Clerk of the Adjutant General's Office; and while the perusal of them cannot fail to be useful and interesting to military men of every rank, it is considered that they will also afford entertainment and information to the general reader, particularly to those who may have served in the Army, or who have relatives in the Service.

There exists in the breasts of most of those who have served, or are serving, in the Army, an *Esprit de Corps*—an attachment to everything belonging to their Regiment; to such persons a narrative of the services of their own Corps cannot fail to prove interesting. Authentic accounts of the actions of the great, the valiant, the loyal, have always been of paramount interest with a brave and civilized people. Great Britain has produced a race of heroes who, in moments of danger and terror, have stood "firm as the rocks of their native shore:" and when half the world has been arrayed against them, they have fought the battles of their Country with unshaken fortitude. It is presumed that a record of achievements in war,—victories so complete and surprising, gained by our countrymen, our brothers, our fellow citizens in arms,—a record which revives the memory of the brave, and brings their gallant deeds before us,—will certainly prove acceptable to the public.

Biographical Memoirs of the Colonels and other distinguished Officers will be introduced in the Records of their respective Regiments, and the Honorary Distinctions which have, from time to time, been conferred upon each Regiment, as testifying the value and importance of its services, will be faithfully set forth.

As a convenient mode of Publication, the Record of each Regiment will be printed in a distinct number, so that when the whole shall be completed, the Parts may be bound up in numerical succession.

INTRODUCTION

TO

THE INFANTRY.

The natives of Britain have, at all periods, been celebrated for innate courage and unshaken firmness, and the national superiority of the British troops over those of other countries has been evinced in the midst of the most imminent perils. History contains so many proofs of extraordinary acts of bravery, that no doubts can be raised upon the facts which are recorded. It must therefore be admitted, that the distinguishing feature of the British soldier is INTREPIDITY. This quality was evinced by the inhabitants of England when their country was invaded by Julius Cæsar with a Roman army, on which occasion the undaunted Britons rushed into the sea to attack the Roman soldiers as they descended from their ships; and, although their discipline and arms were inferior to those of their adversaries, yet their fierce and dauntless bearing intimidated the flower of the Roman troops, including Cæsar's favourite tenth legion. Their arms consisted of spears, short swords, and other weapons of rude construction. They had chariots, to the axles of which were fastened sharp pieces of iron resembling scythe-blades, and infantry in long chariots resembling waggons, who alighted and fought on foot, and for change of ground, pursuit or retreat, sprang into the chariot and drove off with the speed of cavalry. These inventions were, however, unavailing against Cæsar's legions: in the course of time a military system, with discipline and subordination, was introduced, and British courage, being thus regulated, was exerted to the greatest advantage; a full development of the national character followed, and it shone forth in all its native brilliancy.

The military force of the Anglo-Saxons consisted principally of infantry: Thanes, and other men of property, however, fought on horseback. The

infantry were of two classes, heavy and light. The former carried large shields armed with spikes, long broad swords and spears; and the latter were armed with swords or spears only. They had also men armed with clubs, others with battle-axes and javelins.

The feudal troops established by William the Conqueror consisted (as already stated in the Introduction to the Cavalry) almost entirely of horse; but when the warlike barons and knights, with their trains of tenants and vassals, took the field, a proportion of men appeared on foot, and, although these were of inferior degree, they proved stout-hearted Britons of stanch fidelity. When stipendiary troops were employed, infantry always constituted a considerable portion of the military force; and this *arme* has since acquired, in every quarter of the globe, a celebrity never exceeded by the armies of any nation at any period.

The weapons carried by the infantry, during the several reigns succeeding the Conquest, were bows and arrows, half-pikes, lances, halberds, various kinds of battle-axes, swords, and daggers. Armour was worn on the head and body, and in course of time the practice became general for military men to be so completely cased in steel, that it was almost impossible to slay them.

The introduction of the use of gunpowder in the destructive purposes of war, in the early part of the fourteenth century, produced a change in the arms and equipment of the infantry-soldier. Bows and arrows gave place to various kinds of fire-arms, but British archers continued formidable adversaries; and, owing to the inconvenient construction and imperfect bore of the fire-arms when first introduced, a body of men, well trained in the use of the bow from their youth, was considered a valuable acquisition to every army, even as late as the sixteenth century.

During a great part of the reign of Queen Elizabeth each company of infantry usually consisted of men armed five different ways; in every hundred men forty were "*men-at-arms*," and sixty "*shot*;" the "*men-at-arms*" were ten halberdiers, or battle-axe men, and thirty pikemen; and the "*shot*" were twenty archers, twenty musketeers, and twenty harquebusiers, and each man carried, besides his principal weapon, a sword and dagger.

Companies of infantry varied at this period in numbers from 150 to 300 men; each company had a colour or ensign, and the mode of formation

recommended by an English military writer (Sir John Smithe) in 1590 was: —the colour in the centre of the company guarded by the halberdiers; the pikemen in equal proportions, on each flank of the halberdiers: half the musketeers on each flank of the pikes; half the archers on each flank of the musketeers, and the harquebusiers (whose arms were much lighter than the muskets then in use) in equal proportions on each flank of the company for skirmishing.^[1] It was customary to unite a number of companies into one body, called a REGIMENT, which frequently amounted to three thousand men: but each company continued to carry a colour. Numerous improvements were eventually introduced in the construction of fire-arms, and, it having been found impossible to make armour proof against the muskets then in use (which carried a very heavy ball) without its being too weighty for the soldier, armour was gradually laid aside by the infantry in the seventeenth century: bows and arrows also fell into disuse, and the infantry were reduced to two classes, viz.: *musketeers*, armed with matchlock muskets, swords, and daggers; and *pikemen*, armed with pikes from fourteen to eighteen feet long, and swords.

In the early part of the seventeenth century Gustavus Adolphus, King of Sweden, reduced the strength of regiments to 1000 men. He caused the gunpowder, which had heretofore been carried in flasks, or in small wooden bandoliers, each containing a charge, to be made up into cartridges, and carried in pouches; and he formed each regiment into two wings of musketeers, and a centre division of pikemen. He also adopted the practice of forming four regiments into a brigade; and the number of colours was afterwards reduced to three in each regiment. He formed his columns so compactly that his infantry could resist the charge of the celebrated Polish horsemen and Austrian cuirassiers; and his armies became the admiration of other nations. His mode of formation was copied by the English, French, and other European states; but so great was the prejudice in favour of ancient customs, that all his improvements were not adopted until near a century afterwards.

In 1664 King Charles II. raised a corps for sea-service, styled the Admiral's regiment. In 1678 each company of 100 men usually consisted of 30 pikemen, 60 musketeers, and 10 men armed with light firelocks. In this year the King added a company of men armed with hand grenades to each of the old British regiments, which was designated the "grenadier

company." Daggers were so contrived as to fit in the muzzles of the muskets, and bayonets similar to those at present in use were adopted about twenty years afterwards.

An Ordnance regiment was raised in 1685, by order of King James II., to guard the artillery, and was designated the Royal Fusiliers (now 7th Foot). This corps, and the companies of grenadiers, did not carry pikes.

King William III. incorporated the Admiral's regiment in the second Foot Guards, and raised two Marine regiments for sea-service. During the war in this reign, each company of infantry (excepting the fusiliers and grenadiers) consisted of 14 pikemen and 46 musketeers; the captains carried pikes; lieutenants, partisans; ensigns, half-pikes; and serjeants, halberds. After the peace in 1697 the Marine regiments were disbanded, but were again formed on the breaking out of the war in 1702. ^[2]

During the reign of Queen Anne the pikes were laid aside, and every infantry soldier was armed with a musket, bayonet, and sword; the grenadiers ceased, about the same period, to carry hand grenades; and the regiments were directed to lay aside their third colour: the corps of Royal Artillery was first added to the Army in this reign.

About the year 1745, the men of the battalion companies of infantry ceased to carry swords; during the reign of George II. light companies were added to infantry regiments; and in 1764 a Board of General Officers recommended that the grenadiers should lay aside their swords, as that weapon had never been used during the Seven Years' War. Since that period the arms of the infantry soldier have been limited to the musket and bayonet.

The arms and equipment of the British Troops have seldom differed materially, since the Conquest, from those of other European states; and in some respects the arming has, at certain periods, been allowed to be inferior to that of the nations with whom they have had to contend; yet, under this disadvantage, the bravery and superiority of the British infantry have been evinced on very many and most trying occasions, and splendid victories have been gained over very superior numbers.

Great Britain has produced a race of lion-like champions who have dared to confront a host of foes, and have proved themselves valiant with any

arms. At *Creçy*, King Edward III., at the head of about 30,000 men, defeated, on the 26th of August, 1346, Philip King of France, whose army is said to have amounted to 100,000 men; here British valour encountered veterans of renown:—the King of Bohemia, the King of Majorca, and many princes and nobles were slain, and the French army was routed and cut to pieces. Ten years afterwards, Edward Prince of Wales, who was designated the Black Prince, defeated, at *Poictiers*, with 14,000 men, a French army of 60,000 horse, besides infantry, and took John I., King of France, and his son Philip, prisoners. On the 25th of October, 1415, King Henry V., with an army of about 13,000 men, although greatly exhausted by marches, privations, and sickness, defeated, at *Agincourt*, the Constable of France, at the head of the flower of the French nobility and an army said to amount to 60,000 men, and gained a complete victory.

During the seventy years' war between the United Provinces of the Netherlands and the Spanish monarchy, which commenced in 1578 and terminated in 1648, the British infantry in the service of the States-General were celebrated for their unconquerable spirit and firmness;^[3] and in the thirty years' war between the Protestant Princes and the Emperor of Germany, the British Troops in the service of Sweden and other states were celebrated for deeds of heroism.^[4] In the wars of Queen Anne, the fame of the British army under the great MARLBOROUGH was spread throughout the world; and if we glance at the achievements performed within the memory of persons now living, there is abundant proof that the Britons of the present age are not inferior to their ancestors in the qualities which constitute good soldiers. Witness the deeds of the brave men, of whom there are many now surviving, who fought in Egypt in 1801, under the brave Abercromby, and compelled the French army, which had been vainly styled *Invincible*, to evacuate that country; also the services of the gallant Troops during the arduous campaigns in the Peninsula, under the immortal WELLINGTON; and the determined stand made by the British Army at Waterloo, where Napoleon Bonaparte, who had long been the inveterate enemy of Great Britain, and had sought and planned her destruction by every means he could devise, was compelled to leave his vanquished legions to their fate, and to place himself at the disposal of the British Government. These achievements, with others of recent dates in the distant climes of India, prove that the same valour and constancy which glowed in

the breasts of the heroes of Crécy, Poitiers, Agincourt, Blenheim, and Ramillies, continue to animate the Britons of the nineteenth century.

The British Soldier is distinguished for a robust and muscular frame,—intrepidity which no danger can appal,—unconquerable spirit and resolution,—patience in fatigue and privation, and cheerful obedience to his superiors. These qualities, united with an excellent system of order and discipline to regulate and give a skilful direction to the energies and adventurous spirit of the hero, and a wise selection of officers of superior talent to command, whose presence inspires confidence,—have been the leading causes of the splendid victories gained by the British arms.^[5] The fame of the deeds of the past and present generations in the various battle-fields where the robust sons of Albion have fought and conquered, surrounds the British arms with a halo of glory; these achievements will live in the page of history to the end of time.

The records of the several regiments will be found to contain a detail of facts of an interesting character, connected with the hardships, sufferings, and gallant exploits of British soldiers in the various parts of the world where the calls of their Country and the commands of their Sovereign have required them to proceed in the execution of their duty, whether in active continental operations, or in maintaining colonial territories in distant and unfavourable climes.

The superiority of the British infantry has been pre-eminently set forth in the wars of six centuries, and admitted by the greatest commanders which Europe has produced. The formations and movements of this *arme*, as at present practised, while they are adapted to every species of warfare, and to all probable situations and circumstances of service, are calculated to show forth the brilliancy of military tactics calculated upon mathematical and scientific principles. Although the movements and evolutions have been copied from the continental armies, yet various improvements have from time to time been introduced, to ensure that simplicity and celerity by which the superiority of the national military character is maintained. The rank and influence, which Great Britain has attained among the nations of the world, have in a great measure been purchased by the valour of the Army, and to persons, who have the welfare of their country at heart, the records of the several regiments cannot fail to prove interesting.

FOOTNOTES:

[1] A company of 200 men would appear thus:—

				9					
20	20	20	30	20	30	20	20	20	
Harquebuses.		Muskets.	Halberds.		Muskets.		Harquebuses.		
	Archers.		Pikes.		Pikes.		Archers.		

The musket carried a ball which weighed $\frac{1}{10}$ th of a pound; and the harquebus a ball which weighed $\frac{1}{25}$ th of a pound.

[2] The 30th, 31st, and 32nd Regiments were formed as Marine corps in 1702, and were employed as such during the wars in the reign of Queen Anne. The Marine corps were embarked in the Fleet under Admiral Sir George Rooke, and were at the taking of Gibraltar, and in its subsequent defence in 1704; they were afterwards employed at the siege of Barcelona in 1705.

[3] The brave Sir Roger Williams, in his Discourse on War, printed in 1590, observes:—"I persuade myself ten thousand of our nation would beat thirty thousand of theirs (the Spaniards) out of the field, let them be chosen where they list." Yet at this time the Spanish infantry was allowed to be the best disciplined in Europe. For instances of valour displayed by the British Infantry during the Seventy Years' War, see the Historical Record of the Third Foot, or Buffs.

[4] *Vide* the Historical Record of the First, or Royal Regiment of Foot.

[5] "Under the blessing of Divine Providence, His Majesty ascribes the successes which have attended the exertions of his troops in Egypt to that determined bravery which is inherent in Britons; but His Majesty desires it may be most solemnly and forcibly impressed on the consideration of every part of the army, that it has been a strict observance of order, discipline, and military system, which has given the full energy to the native valour of the troops, and has enabled them proudly to assert the superiority of the national military character, in situations uncommonly arduous, and under circumstances of peculiar difficulty."—*General Orders in 1801*.

In the General Orders issued by Lieut.-General Sir John Hope (afterwards Lord Hopetoun), congratulating the army upon the successful result of the Battle of Corunna, on the 16th of January, 1809, it is stated:—"On no occasion has the undaunted valour of British troops ever been more manifest. At the termination of a severe and harassing march, rendered necessary by the superiority which the enemy had acquired, and which had materially impaired the efficiency of the troops, many disadvantages were to be encountered. These have all been surmounted by the conduct of the troops themselves; and the enemy has been

taught, that whatever advantages of position or of numbers he may possess, there is inherent in the British officers and soldiers a bravery that knows not how to yield,—that no circumstances can appal,—and that will ensure victory when it is to be obtained by the exertion of any human means."



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FIFTY THIRD REGIMENT.

For Cannon's Military Records

HISTORICAL RECORD
OF THE
FIFTY-THIRD,
OR
THE SHROPSHIRE REGIMENT OF FOOT.

1755

In the winter of 1755, when the attacks made by the French on the British settlements beyond the Allegany Mountains, in North America, appeared to render a war between the two countries inevitable, King George II. resolved to augment the strength of his regular army, and a letter of service was addressed to Colonel William Whitmore, major in the third foot guards, authorizing him to raise, form, and discipline a regiment of foot, of ten companies, which was numbered the FIFTY-FIFTH; but two colonial corps being soon afterwards disbanded, viz., Major-General Shirley's and Major-General Sir William Pepperell's, which had been numbered the Fiftieth and Fifty-first regiments, it obtained rank as FIFTY-THIRD regiment. ^[6]

This regiment was raised in the south of England: its uniform was cocked hats; red coats, faced with red, lined with yellow, and ornamented with yellow lace; red waistcoats and breeches, and white gaiters. The colonelcy was conferred on Colonel William Whitmore, by commission dated the 21st of December, 1755; the lieut.-colonelcy was given to Major George Craufurd, from the thirty-fifth regiment, then in Ireland; and Captain William Arnot was nominated major.

1756

Early in 1756 the formation of the regiment was completed, and the following officers were appointed to commissions in the corps:—

Colonel, William Whitmore.

Lieutenant-Colonel, Geo. Craufurd.

Major, Wm. Arnot.

Captains.

John Lindsay.

Geo. Sempill.

Tho. Thompson.

Jas. Wakeman.

Tho. Benson.

Captain-Lieut., Lord

Jas. McFarlane.

Robert Lamb.

Viscount Allen.

Lieutenants.

Geo. O. Kenlock.

Jas. Worsley.

John Slowe.

Rob. Wright.

Jno. Campbell.

Wm. Hughes.

Chs. Chambre.

Jno. Donellan.

Tho. Dyson.

John Manmore.

Ensigns.

Cha. L. Richards.

Geo. Massey.

Dougal Ewart.

Tho. Moore.

Lodovick Grant.

Geo. C. Brown.

John Wright.

Westley Groves.

Jas. Frognorton.

Chaplain, Geo. Watkins.

Adjutant, J. Frognorton.

Surgeon, Tho. London.

Quarter-Master, Cosmo Gordon.

The formation of the regiment being completed, it received orders to embark for Gibraltar, and was stationed at that important fortress during the whole of the seven years' war, and remained there until 1768.

1758

1759

In October, 1758, Colonel Whitmore was removed to the ninth regiment of foot; and was succeeded in the colonelcy of the FIFTY-THIRD, in April, 1759, by Colonel John Toovey, from lieut.-colonel in the royal dragoons.

1768

The regiment was relieved from duty at the fortress of Gibraltar in 1768, when it embarked for Ireland, where it was quartered during the following eight years.

1770

Colonel Toovey died in the early part of the year 1770, and King George III. conferred the colonelcy on Colonel R. Dalrymple Horne Elphinstone, who had commanded the 120th regiment of foot, which was disbanded after the peace in 1763.

1775

While the regiment was stationed in Ireland, the misunderstanding between Great Britain and her North American provinces on the subject of taxation, was followed by open hostilities; and a body of American troops undertook the siege of *Quebec*.

1776

In the spring of 1776 the FIFTY-THIRD and several other corps proceeded, under Major-General Burgoyne, for the relief of Quebec: this regiment embarked from Ireland on the 4th of April, arrived in Canada towards the end of May, and took part in the operations by which the American troops were driven from the confines of the British provinces. During the winter the regiment was stationed at Chambly.

1777

The flank companies of the regiment were selected, in the spring of 1777, to form part of the force under Lieut.-General Burgoyne, who was directed to penetrate the United States from Lake Champlain to the river Hudson, and advance upon Albany, with the view of bringing that part of the country into submission to the British crown. The troops employed on this service proceeded to Crown Point in boats, and afterwards moved towards Ticonderoga, forcing the Americans to abandon that post, and pursuing them a considerable distance. Some fighting occurred, in which the British soldiers evinced great gallantry, and the companies of the FIFTY-THIRD had opportunities of distinguishing themselves. The army advanced towards the river Hudson, encountering much greater difficulties than had been expected. The country through which it marched was a wilderness; numerous obstructions had to be removed, forty bridges had to be constructed, and others repaired; but every difficulty was overcome by the cheerful perseverance of the soldiers. Their hardships were, however, daily

augmented; and after passing the river Hudson, they were opposed by very superior numbers of the enemy. Several actions occurred, and British valour was conspicuous; but incessant toil and a scarcity of provisions reduced the army to 3500 men, who were environed by 16,000 Americans, and their retreat cut off. Under these circumstances a convention was concluded, by which the British agreed to lay down their arms on condition of being sent to England. The Americans afterwards violated the conditions of the convention, and detained the English soldiers some time.

1778
1781

Eight companies of the regiment had remained in Canada, where they were eventually joined by the flank companies, and the regiment was stationed in that part of the British dominions several years.

1782

The American war terminated in 1782:—In the same year the regiment received instructions to assume the title of the FIFTY-THIRD, OR THE SHROPSHIRE REGIMENT, and to cultivate a connexion with that county, which might, at all times, be useful towards recruiting.

1789
1790

In the summer of 1789 the regiment, being then in garrison at Quebec, was relieved by the twenty-fourth foot, and embarked for England, where it landed on the 31st of August. It passed the winter at Bridgenorth, and towards the end of the year 1790 embarked on board the fleet to serve as marines, on which service it was employed a short time.

1791
1792

Embarking from Plymouth on the 17th of February, 1791, the regiment proceeded to Glasgow, and was stationed in Scotland during the year 1792.

1793

In the meantime a revolution had taken place in France, and in 1793 the republicans of that country beheaded their king. They also attacked the

frontiers of Holland, when a body of British troops was sent to the Netherlands to take part in the war. The FIFTY-THIRD regiment was one of the first corps selected to proceed on foreign service; it embarked from Scotland in March, and, after landing in Flanders, advanced up the country to Tournay.

The regiment formed part of the column under the command of His Royal Highness the Duke of York, which passed the Ronelle river on the 23rd of May, and forced the French to quit several batteries of their strong camp at *Famars*. It was stated in the public despatch sent to England on this occasion—"The troops of the different nations displayed the utmost firmness and intrepidity. The British who had an opportunity of distinguishing themselves, were the fourteenth and FIFTY-THIRD regiments, with the battalion formed from the light infantry and grenadier companies, commanded by Major-General Sir Ralph Abercromby." The regiment lost four men on this occasion.

This success was followed by the siege of *Valenciennes*, in which service the regiment was actively employed, and had several men killed and wounded. It also sustained some loss at the storming of the outworks on the 25th of July, which was followed by the surrender of the fortress.

From *Valenciennes* the British troops proceeded towards *Dunkirk*, which place was besieged; but circumstances occurred which rendered it necessary for the army to withdraw from this position: and the FIFTY-THIRD regiment was detached to the town of *Nieuport*. The French made a strenuous effort to capture this place on the 24th of October, by a *coup-de-main*, when the FIFTY-THIRD resisted the attack of a very superior force, with heroic gallantry, and their commanding officer, Major Robert Matthews, particularly distinguished himself. The gallant conduct of the regiment on this occasion excited universal admiration. Its loss was Lieutenant Phaniel Latham and ten soldiers killed; Captain Ronald C. Fergusson and eighteen soldiers wounded. The French continued to cannonade the place several days, causing the regiment a further loss of thirteen men; but the garrison being augmented, the enemy retired. General Sir Charles (afterwards Earl) Grey, who arrived with a reinforcement, stated in his despatch—"The artillery under Captain Bothwick, with the FIFTY-THIRD regiment, whose loss has been greatest, have been very much distinguished; and I think it only an act of justice to mention in terms of the highest approbation Major

Matthews (commanding the FIFTY-THIRD), whose long services and particular exertions on this occasion will, I hope, recommend him to His Majesty's notice."

The Royal authority was given for the regiment to bear the word "Nieuport" on its colours, to commemorate its distinguished conduct in the defence of that fortress.

1794

General Elphinstone died in the spring of 1794, when the colonelcy of the regiment was conferred on Major-General Gerard Lake, from lieut.-colonel in the first foot guards.

Taking the field in April of this year, the regiment was engaged in the operations by which the enemy was driven from his positions at *Vaux*, *Prémont*, *Marets*, &c., on the 17th of that month, when the Duke of York expressed in general orders the sense he entertained of the bravery and conduct of the troops engaged.

The regiment was subsequently employed in covering the siege of *Landrécies*; it was in line on the 26th of April, when the attack of the French on the British position at *Cateau* was repulsed; and after the surrender of *Landrécies*, the regiment marched to the vicinity of *Tournay*.

On the 10th of May the position near *Tournay* was attacked, and the French were repulsed with severe loss.

A combined attack on the posts occupied by the French army was made on the 17th of May; when the FOURTEENTH, THIRTY-SEVENTH, and FIFTY-THIRD regiments, forming the second brigade, under Major-General Fox,^[7] were attached to the column under the Duke of York's immediate command, which captured *Lannoy*, *Roubaix*, and *Mouveaux*; and the three regiments were afterwards posted on the main road from *Lisle* to *Roubaix*. Meanwhile the failure of the other columns of the allied army had left the British troops exposed to the whole weight and power of the enemy's overwhelming numbers, and early on the 18th of May the fourteenth, thirty-seventh, and FIFTY-THIRD regiments were attacked by a numerous force. A historian of that campaign states,—"Major-General Fox, with the fourteenth, thirty-seventh, and FIFTY-THIRD regiments, was engaged with the whole of the

column which had marched from Lisle, and the different corps, which had driven back the rest of the army, fell upon his flanks and rear. Perhaps there is not on record a single instance of greater gallantry and more soldier-like conduct than was exhibited on that occasion by these three regiments. At length Major-General Fox, finding that the whole army had left him, began to think of retreating; to effect which it was necessary to get possession of the causeway leading to Leers, and before that could be accomplished, he was obliged to charge several battalions of the enemy, who were astonished that such a handful of men should presume to give them battle, and expected every moment that they would lay down their arms; but with a degree of intrepidity that words cannot describe, and is, indeed, scarcely conceivable, they gained the wished-for point; then forming with such regularity that the enemy could not assail them, they secured their retreat towards Leers, and the next morning joined General Otto's column. This brigade, which consisted of only eleven hundred and twenty men, left in the field five hundred and thirty-three."^[8]

The FIFTY-THIRD regiment had Lieutenant John Rhind, eight serjeants, two drummers, and one hundred and ninety-one rank and file killed and missing; Major Thomas Scott, Captain Thomas Brisbane, Ensign E. Pierce, one serjeant, and fourteen rank and file wounded.^[9]

Resuming its post in front of *Tournay*, the regiment was in line on the 22nd of May, when a numerous French army attacked the position occupied by the allies. The right wing of the army being pressed by the enemy, Major-General Fox's brigade was detached to its support. Speaking of the FOURTEENTH, THIRTY-SEVENTH, and FIFTY-THIRD regiments on this occasion, the Duke of York stated in his despatch, "Nothing could exceed the spirit and gallantry with which they conducted themselves, particularly in the storming of the village of *Pontéchin*, which they forced with the bayonet. The enemy immediately began to retreat." In general orders it was stated, "His Royal Highness the Commander-in-Chief desires to express his particular thanks to Major-General Fox; to the fourteenth regiment, under the command of Major Ramsey; to the thirty-seventh regiment, commanded by Captain Lightburne; to the FIFTY-THIRD regiment, commanded by Major Wiseman; and to the detachment of artillery that was attached to them, under the command of Captain Trotter, for their intrepidity and good conduct, which reflects the greatest honor upon themselves, at the same

time that it was highly instrumental in deciding the important victory of the 22nd instant."

In Jones's Journal it is stated:—"There never was a better opportunity of putting British valour to the test; nor could there be anything more conspicuous than the proof they gave of what highly disciplined soldiers, well led on, may be brought to do. It appears almost impossible; but it is a fact, that a single British brigade, less than six hundred men, on that great day absolutely won the battle; for had they not come up, the allies would have been beaten."

The regiment had six rank and file killed: Lieutenants Rogers and Robertson, Ensign Pierce, one serjeant, and twenty-three rank and file wounded; twelve rank and file missing.

The word "TOURNAY," displayed by royal authority on the colour of the regiment, commemorates its heroic conduct on this occasion.

The enemy afterwards acquired so great a superiority of numbers, that the British army withdrew from its position, and a series of retrograde movements brought the army to the banks of the Rhine and the Waal.

1795

A severe frost having rendered the rivers passable on the ice, the British troops retired through Holland to Germany. The FIFTY-THIRD shared in the toil, privation, and suffering occasioned by long marches through a country covered with ice and snow: in the spring of 1795 they embarked for England, where they arrived in May.

The regiment was encamped near Southampton, where its ranks were completed by drafts from the 109th regiment; in November it embarked for the West Indies, and afterwards sailed with the armament, under General Sir Ralph Abercromby, for the conquest of the French West India Islands. The disasters which befell this fleet from storms at sea, and the number of shipwrecks which took place, are recorded in the naval history of Great Britain.

1796

Four companies of the regiment, commanded by Major Brisbane, arrived at Barbadoes in March, 1796, and they formed part of the armament which proceeded against *St. Lucia*; three other companies also arrived in time to share in the enterprise. A landing was effected on the 26th and 27th of April, and at midnight on the last-mentioned day, Brigadier-General (afterwards Sir John) Moore advanced with seven companies of the FIFTY-THIRD, under Lieut.-Colonel John Abercromby, and a detachment of Rangers along a defile in the mountains, and falling in with the enemy's post at *Morne Chabot*, carried it after a considerable resistance. The FIFTY-THIRD distinguished themselves on this occasion; and Sir Ralph Abercromby's thanks were expressed to the regiment in orders, accompanied by the declaration that he would bring its conduct before His Royal Highness the Duke of York.

The loss of the regiment on this occasion was one drummer and twelve rank and file killed; Captain Charles Stuart, Lieutenant Richard Collins, and John Carmichael, two serjeants, forty-four rank and file wounded; one drummer and eight private soldiers missing.

The regiment was engaged in the subsequent operations for the reduction of the island, which was accomplished before the end of May; and the Royal authority was given for the word "ST. LUCIA" to be borne on the colours of the regiment, to commemorate its distinguished conduct on this service.

After the reduction of St. Lucia, the regiment was embarked for St. Vincent, where an insurrection had broken out, and the native Caribs and many French colonists were in arms against the British authority. The insurgents were speedily overcome, and the Caribs fled to the woods. The hostile spirit which these people had long shown towards the British interests, occasioned the government to resolve to remove them from the island. The measures for this purpose were attended with much harassing duty to the troops, and many skirmishes occurred; but the Caribs were eventually forced to submit. The regiment was afterwards withdrawn from the island, when it received the following communication from Major-General Peter Hunter, dated 26th November, 1796:—

"SIR,—I beg you, and the officers and soldiers of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment, under your command, will accept of my best thanks for the zeal,

activity, and humanity which have been testified by you and them, on all occasions, while under my command, during the brigand and Caribbee war in the island of St. Vincent. I am also requested by the Council and Assembly of the island to communicate, not only to the officers and soldiers now serving in St. Vincent, but to all those whom I have had the honor to command since my arrival here, the sentiments that the Assembly and inhabitants of this colony entertain of the good conduct and behaviour of the troops, and to offer their warmest, most grateful, and unfeigned thanks for the eminent services the army has rendered this island."

Major-General Lake having been removed to the seventy-third regiment, he was succeeded in the colonelcy of the FIFTY-THIRD by Major-General Welbore Ellis Doyle, by commission dated the 2nd of November, 1796.

1797

Spain having united with France in hostility to Great Britain, the FIFTY-THIRD were employed in an expedition against the Spanish settlement of *Trinidad*, which was captured in February, 1797, without loss.

The army subsequently proceeded against *Porto Rico*, and a landing was effected on the 18th of April; but the expedition proved of insufficient strength for the capture of this place, and the troops re-embarked on the night of the 30th of April. The FIFTY-THIRD had three rank and file killed; Captain John Rhind and three men wounded; Captain Samuel Dover taken prisoner. The regiment returned to St. Vincent.

1798

On the death of Major-General Doyle, the colonelcy was conferred on Lieut.-General Charles Crosbie, from the late Royal Dublin regiment, his commission bearing date the 3rd of January, 1798.

1799

1800

After remaining at St. Vincent during the years 1798 and 1799, the regiment was removed to St. Lucia in 1800.

1802

At the peace of Amiens, in 1802, the island of St. Lucia was restored to France, when the regiment returned to England, much reduced in numbers by the climate of the West Indies.

1803

On the arrival of the regiment in England, the men enlisted for limited service were discharged at Hilsea barracks, and in January, 1803, it marched, under the command of Lieut.-Colonel Lightburne, for Shrewsbury.

1805

The first battalion, having been completed to eight hundred rank and file, embarked at Portsmouth, on the 20th of April, 1805, for the East Indies, under the orders of Lieut.-Colonel Sebright Mawby. The fleet sailed under the convoy of His Majesty's ship "Blenheim," on the 24th of April: in the early part of August it encountered a French line-of-battle ship and a frigate, when some firing took place, but nothing serious occurred; and on the 23rd of that month it arrived in Madras roads, when the FIFTY-THIRD landed, and marched into Fort St. George, where they lost a very promising officer, Captain Henry Knight Erskine, whose death was much regretted. In October they proceeded in boats to the fertile district of Dinapore, on the right bank of the Ganges, and occupied that station, in the midst of a country abounding with grain, cattle, and sheep.

1806

In consequence of the unhealthy state of the battalion, it was withdrawn from Dinapore, when Major-General Clarke expressed, in orders, his approbation of its conduct while under his command, and the high sense he entertained of the zeal and abilities of Lieut.-Colonel Mawby and of the officers generally. It arrived at Berhampore, a considerable station on the left bank of the Hoogly river, on the 6th of July.

1807

General Crosbie having died, the colonelcy was conferred on Major-General the Honorable John Abercromby, by commission dated the 21st of March, 1807, the sixth anniversary of the battle of Alexandria.

In September the first battalion embarked in boats to proceed up the Ganges, when Major-General Palmer recorded, in orders, his approbation of its exemplary conduct while stationed at Berhampore. After a voyage of eleven weeks in boats up the river, the battalion landed at Cawnpore on the 29th of November, and marched into the spacious barracks on an elevated site at that place.

The gallant conduct of two serjeants and fourteen private soldiers of the first battalion on board of the Company's ship *Fame*, when it was captured by a French frigate (the *Piedmontaise*), was rewarded by a donation from the Court of Directors, of 5*l.* to each of the serjeants, and 4*l.* to each private soldier.

The first battalion was stationed at Cawnpore during the year, and was highly commended in orders for its correct discipline and excellent conduct.

1809

On the 19th of January, 1809, three companies were detached, under Captain Piercy, to the province of Bundelcund, and joining the troops under Lieut.-Colonel Martindell, were employed in reducing some refractory native Sirdars. These companies were at the siege and capture of the fort of *Adjighion*, situate upon a lofty mountain; and after the surrender of this place they rejoined the regiment, which took the field in November, and joined a numerous division under Lieut.-Colonel Martindell. This body of troops was called out in consequence of signs of defection in the native Madras army, and it performed many long and difficult marches.

1810

The first battalion continued in the field until March, 1810, when it returned to Cawnpore. Lieut.-Colonel Mawby, the officers and soldiers, received the thanks of the Commander of the field force for their excellent conduct.

1811

During the year 1811 the first battalion remained at Cawnpore, where Lieut.-Colonel Buckland assumed the command.

Five companies of the first battalion proceeded from their quarters at Cawnpore to take part with the division under Colonel Martindell, in the reduction of the strong fortress of *Callinger*, before which place the troops arrived on the 19th of January, 1812. A breach having been reported practicable, the fortress was assaulted on the 2nd of February. A serjeant and twelve privates of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment formed the forlorn-hope, which led the assault of the breach; they were followed by the grenadiers and light infantry of the FIFTY-THIRD, under Captain Fraser, supported by the remaining three companies of the FIFTY-THIRD, and the grenadiers and light infantry of the native regiments. The fortress of Callinger is situated upon a high rock of difficult access and great extent, in one of the ranges of mountains in the province of Allahabad; and when that portion of the country was ceded to the British, this strong fortress, which had resisted native armies, became the asylum of the disaffected and of the banditti of the province. These desperate characters crowded the breach as the FIFTY-THIRD rushed forward to storm the works. Select marksmen of the garrison were supplied with loaded muskets by other men as fast as they could fire them, and huge stones were in readiness to be thrown upon the assailants. The signal being given, the storming party, under the orders of Lieut.-Colonel Sebright Mawby and the officers and soldiers of the FIFTY-THIRD, made a gallant effort to gain the breach; ladders were placed against the rock and the men ascended with enthusiastic ardour; but showers of huge stones and a storm of musketry destroyed every man who gained the top of the rock; at the same time it was found impracticable to get other ladders fixed to communicate with a second small projection of the rock which appeared in the breach; under these circumstances the storming party was ordered to retire. The FIFTY-THIRD had Captain Fraser, Lieutenant and Adjutant Nice, one serjeant, one corporal, and ten private soldiers killed; Captain Cuppage, Lieutenants Stone, Young, Stewart, Daly, Cruice, Davis, and Booth, and one hundred and twenty soldiers wounded; several men died of their wounds.

In regimental orders issued on the 3rd of February, it was stated:—"Lieut.-Colonel Mawby has not words to express his admiration of the conduct of every officer and soldier of the FIFTY-THIRD in the storm of yesterday; anything he could say on the occasion would fall very short of

what they deserved, for greater bravery and perseverance never were displayed by men, and had it been possible to have carried the breach, their bravery would have done it. His feelings for the severe loss sustained by the regiment may be imagined, but cannot be expressed; it is, however, a great consolation to know that the whole army before Callinger speaks of their bravery in terms of the highest commendation."

The conduct of the storming party was also commended in orders by Colonel Martindell, who stated,—"If the difficulties which they had to surmount had been found of a nature to be overcome, the persevering energy and undaunted courage of the troops, so very admirably conspicuous, would have been crowned with that success, which their animated exertions, and steady cool bravery, so eminently deserved."

In general orders by the government it was stated, "His Lordship in Council cordially unites in the sentiments of admiration expressed by His Excellency the Commander-in-Chief, of the exemplary exertions, zeal, and persevering courage manifested by Lieut.-Colonel Mawby, FIFTY-THIRD regiment, and the brave officers and men acting under his command."

Lieut.-Colonel Mawby particularly reported the gallant conduct of Serjeant-Major Thomas Clarke, of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment.

In consequence of the difficulty experienced in the reduction of Callinger, Major Piercy, who commanded the five companies of the regiment left at Cawnpore, received orders to proceed as rapidly as possible to join the besieging army; but before he arrived, the garrison had surrendered. The cool determined bravery of the officers and soldiers of the FIFTY-THIRD, at the storming of the breach, had produced a great impression on the defenders of the fortress, who declared to their commander, that they would not stand a second assault: the Killedar, therefore, was forced to capitulate and deliver up the fortress.

The regiment afterwards returned to Cawnpore, where its appearance and discipline elicited the commendations of the Commander-in-Chief in India at a review in September of this year. In October the regiment marched to Meerut on the north-west frontier.

1813

During the year 1813 the first battalion was stationed at Meerut.

In the meantime circumstances had occurred which occasioned the battalion to be called from its quarters at Meerut, to take the field against the Nepaulese, whose depredations on the British territory could not be restrained without force of arms. The FIFTY-THIRD marched from Meerut on the 14th of October, and joined the division of the army appointed to invade the kingdom of Nepaul, or the Gorca state, under the orders of Major-General Robert Rollo Gillespie. This division was directed to penetrate the Himalaya mountains by the pass of the Deyrah Doon, and capture the strong fort of *Kalunga*, situate upon a peak in the mountains between the rivers Sutlej and Ganges, which was defended by a garrison of warlike mountaineers, under a celebrated Hindoo warrior named Bulbudder.

1814

Two companies of the FIFTY-THIRD, commanded by Lieutenant Young, were detached with a small column under Lieut.-Colonel Carpenter of the seventeenth native infantry, and ascending the Timlee pass, into the Deyrah valley, joined at midnight on the 24th of October, another detachment under Colonel Mawby of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment, who advanced to capture the fort of *Kalunga* by a *coup-de-main*; but upon approaching the place, it was found to be a strong work of excellent stone masonry, more formidable than it had been represented to be, and not to be taken without cannon. After a close reconnoissance, Colonel Mawby retired, and received the acknowledgments of Major-General Gillespie, in orders, for his conduct on the occasion. The Major-General afterwards advanced with the leading corps, and taking with him a few light field-pieces on the backs of elephants, had them placed in battery upon a piece of table-land near the fort, and on the morning of the 31st of October storming parties were in readiness to attack the fort. The troops moved forward with great gallantry, but under such unfavourable circumstances, that the assault failed; among the other disasters the pioneers bearing the ladders fell, from the fire of the garrison, in the midst of a village of grass huts, which caught fire, and the storming party was thus deprived of the means for ascending the walls of the fort. The two companies of the FIFTY-THIRD lost several men, and had Lieutenants Young and Anstice severely wounded. Three of the columns of attack had not advanced, in consequence of not hearing, or not understanding, the signal, and the messengers despatched to them never reached their destination. The columns which had advanced, withdrew to

the village. At this moment three companies of the FIFTY-THIRD arrived from a long march, under Captain Wheeler Coultman, and were ordered to join the storming party, which consisted also of a brigade of Bengal horse artillery (six-pounders), under the command of Captain Charles Pratt Kennedy, for the purpose of making another determined effort to capture the place. Major-General Gillespie headed the assault in person. A party of the FIFTY-THIRD dragged two of the guns forward with ropes up a steep ascent under a sharp fire, and after overcoming the difficulty of a stockade across the path, a few shots were fired at a small gate in the wall, to force it open. A destructive fire was opened from the walls upon the storming party, crowded in a narrow space, waiting for the gate to be forced open and a passage to be made; Major-General Gillespie placed himself at the head of the troops, and while leading the men to the assault, he fell mortally wounded. The attack failed; the storming party retired; and afterwards withdrew from before the fort to await the arrival of a battering train. The FIFTY-THIRD had sixteen men killed and seventy-five wounded.

The battering train having arrived from Delhi, the siege was resumed by the troops under Colonel Mawby, and on the 27th of November the flank companies of the FIFTY-THIRD, with one battalion company of the regiment, and the grenadiers of the native corps, stormed the breach under the orders of Major William Ingleby of the FIFTY-THIRD. A numerous body of mountaineers defended the breach with desperate resolution. Major Ingleby was wounded, and withdrew, leaving the storming party under Captain Coultman. Lieutenant Harrington and a few men of the FIFTY-THIRD ascended the breach, but were instantly killed. The storming party proving not sufficiently numerous to capture the place, the remaining companies of the regiment were ordered forward, and the attack was repeated, but without success: the approach to the breach proved very difficult, and the defenders numerous and desperate; after a severe loss had been sustained, the storming party was ordered to retire. Lieutenant Harrington and twenty men of the regiment were killed on this occasion; Major Ingleby, Captain Stone, Lieutenants Horsley, Green, and Brodie, Ensign Aufrere, twelve serjeants, three drummers, and one hundred and eighty-four rank and file wounded.

The battery resumed its fire to widen the breach; but further loss was prevented by the garrison evacuating the fort, and retreating and forcing their way through the besieging corps.

From Kalunga the division moved along a ridge of mountains towards *Nahn*; the enemy evacuating the fortifications as the British approached, and retiring to another ridge of mountains of much greater elevation. On the 27th of December the flank companies of the regiment were engaged in driving back the enemy's outposts, in order to make lodgments for besieging some fortified places on the Jampta heights, and had one serjeant and eight rank and file killed.

1815

In 1815 the Nepaulese were brought to submission, and the regiment marched from the camp in the mountains to the banks of the Ganges, where it embarked in boats and proceeded down the river to Berhampore, where it landed on the 30th of August, and was joined by a strong detachment from the second battalion, under the command of Major Giles. On the 20th of October the regiment again embarked in boats, and proceeded to Calcutta, where it remained until December, when it embarked for Madras.

1816

In January, 1816, the first battalion marched from Madras to Wallajahbad; but in March three companies returned to Madras, and seven proceeded to the Naggerly Pass, to keep in check the plundering bands of *Pindarees*, who infested the British territory in India at this period. These marauding tribes having been driven from British India with severe loss, the seven companies marched to Bangalore, where they were joined by the detachment from Madras in June; also by a detachment from Europe. In November the battalion commenced its march for Trichinopoly, where it arrived on the 12th of December, after a march of two hundred and seven miles.

1817

On the 14th of February, 1817, Lieut.-General Sir John Abercromby, G.C.B., died at Marseilles, in the south of France, at which place he had resided some time for the benefit of his health. The high military character and private virtues of this distinguished officer, with his attachment to, and the lively interest he took in every thing connected with, the FIFTY-THIRD

regiment, occasioned his death to be much regretted. He was succeeded by Lieut.-General Rowland Lord Hill, G.C.B., from the ninety-fourth regiment.

Colonel Mawby commanded the regiment in cantonments at Trichinopoly; and in June the flank companies were detached, under the command of Major Giles, to join a flank battalion forming at Darwah, to serve with a division of the army under Colonel Pritzler, which was called to take the field in consequence of several native chiefs having prepared to wage war against the British power in India.

While the flank companies were in the field, the strength of the regiment was augmented by the detachment from the second battalion, and a number of volunteers from the eightieth regiment.

1818

In 1818 the regiment sustained great loss from the cholera.

1819

The flank companies were actively employed with the field force under Brigadier-General Pritzler, who reduced several fortified places to submission to the British authority, and among others the fort of *Copaul Droog*, the garrison of which place made a desperate defence. The excellent conduct of the troops employed in this service was made known in general orders dated the 22nd of June, 1819. The flank battalion led the assault of the place; and the conduct of Captain Cuppage, and Lieutenant Silver of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment, was particularly noticed. Lieutenant Silver was wounded.

1820

Leaving Trichinopoly in January, 1820, the regiment commenced its march for Bellary, a distance of about three hundred and ninety miles, under the orders of Colonel Mawby. The cholera broke out in the regiment on the march, and it lost a highly esteemed officer, Lieut.-Colonel Fehrszen, who had distinguished himself while serving with the second battalion in Spain and the south of France; he was buried with military honours at Salem. Lieutenant George FitzGerald, who had also served with reputation in the Peninsular War, died a few days afterwards, and was buried at Nimdydroog. While passing through the Mysore, the cholera disappeared; and on the 25th

of February the regiment arrived at Bellary; having lost two officers and eighteen soldiers on the march.

Colonel Mawby having been promoted to the rank of major-general, the command of the regiment devolved on Lieut.-Colonel Mansel.

After halting at Bellary five months, the regiment commenced its march for Bangalore, where it arrived on the 1st of August. Lieutenant John Wilton, a gallant and meritorious officer, died on the 28th of August, much regretted.

The flank battalion, under Major Giles, had continued to perform much arduous and valuable service, under Brigadier-General Pritzler; but the necessity for its continuing in the field having ceased, the several companies marched to join their respective regiments. The companies of the FIFTY-THIRD arrived at head-quarters on the 30th of November. The gallant, zealous, and exemplary conduct of these companies, during the three years and a half which they had been employed on field service, was highly commended in orders. The regiment was at this period commanded by Lieut.-Colonel Edward Carey Fleming.

1821

Major John Giles, who had commanded the flank battalion on field service with reputation, died on the 2nd of May, 1821, at Cannanore. Quarter-master Robert Blackie died soon afterwards; he had risen by merit from the ranks of the regiment, and had held the commission of quarter-master nineteen years: he was much respected in the regiment.

1822

In May, 1822, the regiment quitted the Mysore, having first received the thanks of Lieut.-General Bowser, in division orders, for its exemplary conduct, and proceeded to Fort St. George, where it arrived on the 5th of June; having lost, on this march of two hundred miles, fifteen men by cholera. Major Wheeler Coultman also died on the 22nd of May.

The forty-first regiment arriving from England in July, the FIFTY-THIRD marched out of Fort St. George and encamped at a village on the Poonamallee Road, and were placed under orders for embarkation for England.

1823

Seven hundred and fifty-six non-commissioned officers and soldiers volunteered to transfer their services to other corps, and to remain in India; twenty-one old soldiers were placed on the out-pension of Chelsea Hospital, and permitted to reside in India; and the regiment embarked from Madras on the 9th of March, 1823, after a service of eighteen years in India.^[10] It landed at Gravesend on the 8th of July, and marched to Chatham, where it halted a few days, and afterwards proceeded to Hilsea barracks. It was subsequently removed to Weedon barracks, and active measures were adopted for recruiting its numbers.

1825

1826

In 1825 the regiment proceeded to Chatham, and afterwards to Portsmouth, where it was inspected and reviewed by its colonel, General Lord Hill, in May, 1826, and elicited his Lordship's approbation. It afterwards marched into Lancashire, and in October embarked at Liverpool for Ireland: it landed at Dublin, and marched from thence to Templemore.

1827

Leaving Templemore in the spring of 1827, the regiment proceeded to Cork; and in the autumn the head-quarters were removed to Kilkenny.

1828

1829

In April, 1828, the regiment marched to Dublin; and in the spring of 1829 to Birr, where it was formed into *six service and four reserve companies*, preparatory to the former proceeding to a foreign station.

The service companies proceeded to Cork, where they embarked on the 2nd of November for Gibraltar, and arrived at that important fortress in December.

1830

A pair of new colours bearing the words "NIEUPORT," "TOURNAY," "ST. LUCIA," "TALAVERA," "SALAMANCA," "VITTORIA," "PYRENEES," "NIVELLE," "TOULOUSE," and "PENINSULA," having been received, the regiment was

formed on parade on the 12th of January, 1830, under Lieut.-Colonel James Considine's command; the colours were consecrated by the Rev. J. S. Pering, the garrison Chaplain; they were then handed by the Lieut.-Governor, Sir George Don, to Mrs. Considine, who presented them to the regiment, with a suitable address. The day was concluded by a supper and ball, given by the officers of the regiment, to which the officers in garrison, and the principal inhabitants of the place, were invited. The soldiers were treated with a dinner and a hogshead of wine on the following day; and on the 14th, the serjeants were permitted to treat their friends to a supper and a dance in one of the large store-rooms, which was fitted up for the occasion.

The reserve companies remained in Ireland until May of this year, when they embarked at Dublin, for Liverpool.

In November, 1830, General Lord Hill, G.C.B., G.C.H., K.C., was removed to the Royal regiment of Horse Guards, and was succeeded in the colonelcy of the FIFTY-THIRD by Major-General Lord FitzRoy James Henry Somerset, K.C.B.

1834
1835

The service companies remained on duty at Gibraltar until March, 1834, when they proceeded to the island of Malta, where they remained during the year 1835; in October the depôt companies returned to Ireland.

1836

In the summer of 1836 the service companies embarked at Malta for the Ionian Islands, and landed at Corfu in July.

1840

After remaining nearly four years in the Ionian Islands, the service companies embarked at Corfu on the 28th of April, 1840, for England, and landed on the 9th of June at Plymouth, where they were joined by the depôt companies from Ireland.

1841

The regiment remained at Plymouth until July, 1841, when it embarked for Scotland, and marching to Edinburgh, was stationed in the castle of that

city during the year 1842.

1843

In April, 1843, the regiment proceeded from Edinburgh to Ireland, and was stationed at Belfast until September, when it marched to Enniskillen.

1844

The regiment marched from Enniskillen to Newry in January, 1844, and having been selected to proceed to India, the usual augmentation was made to its numbers. It proceeded to Manchester in July, and embarked at Liverpool for Bengal on the 20th of August under the command of Lieutenant-Colonel Harry Shakespear Phillips, arriving at Calcutta on the 30th of December following.

1845

On the 22nd of January, 1845, the regiment proceeded from Chinsurah to Cawnpore, where it arrived on the 19th of March; in October it marched to Agra, and on the 19th of December to Delhi, where it arrived and encamped on the 28th of December, 1845.

1846

During the brief period which elapsed between the 11th and 23rd of December, 1845, the valley of the *Sutlej* was the scene of active and interesting operations; the frontier of the Punjaub^[11] (*punj*, five, and *aub*, waters) had been crossed by a numerous and well disciplined Sikh army; and the enemy had been repulsed in two sanguinary battles, at *Moodkee* on the 18th of December, and at *Ferozeshah* three days afterwards.

After these successes, it was determined by the Commander-in-Chief in India to rest the main body of the army until strong reinforcements arrived, when a grand attack was to be made on the Sikhs, who had employed the interval in strengthening the position they had taken up on the British side of the river *Sutlej*, the boundary of the Punjaub from India.

Reinforcements accordingly proceeded to the frontier, and the FIFTY-THIRD was one of the regiments ordered to join the Army of the *Sutlej*. The regiment, under the command of Lieutenant-Colonel Harry Shakespear Phillips, marched from Delhi on the 5th of January, 1846, and arrived at

Kurnaul on the 10th of that month: two days afterwards the FIFTY-THIRD marched to join the portion of the army detached under the command of Major-General Sir Harry Smith, who was proceeding to the relief of Loodianah (celebrated for its manufacture of imitative Cashmere shawls), which was threatened by a force of twenty thousand Sikhs under the command of Runjoor Singh. The junction was effected on the 21st of January, on which day the regiment suffered severely from the heavy fire of the enemy's artillery on the march to Loodianah, sustaining a loss of thirty-six men killed. Major-General Sir Harry Smith, by a series of skilful movements, avoided a regular engagement, and effected his communication with Loodianah, but not without severe loss. On the 28th of January the Major-General determined to attack the Sikhs under Runjoor Singh in their strong position at *Aliwal*, and the result was a splendid victory. Runjoor Singh's camp, with all his baggage, ammunition, and stores, fell into the hands of the victors, and the left wing of the Sikh army was thus almost completely disorganised.

Her Majesty's FIFTY-THIRD, and the thirtieth native infantry, formed the third brigade, under Brigadier Wilson, and were opposed upon the left to the "*Aieen*" troops, called *Avitabiles*,^[12] when the conflict was fiercely raging. The enemy, driven back on his left and centre, endeavoured to hold his right to cover the passage of the river, and strongly occupied the village of Bhoondree, which was carried by the FIFTY-THIRD at the point of the bayonet: the regiment then moved forward, in support of the thirtieth native infantry, by the right of the village.

After expressing his thanks to Lieut.-Colonel Phillips of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment, Major-General Sir Harry Smith added in his official despatch:—

"I have only to report upon Her Majesty's FIFTY-THIRD, a young regiment, but veterans in daring gallantry and regularity; and Lieut.-Colonel Phillips's bravery and coolness attracted the attention of myself and every staff-officer I sent to him."

The casualties of the regiment were limited to three men killed and eight wounded.

Although the Sikh army was much disheartened at the sight of the numerous bodies which floated from the battle-field to the bridge of boats at Sobraon, yet in a few days they appeared as confident as ever of being

able to retain their entrenched position, and to prevent the passage of the river.

On the 3rd of February the regiment marched from Aliwal, and joined the head-quarters of the Army of the Sutlej on the 8th of that month.

The heavy ordnance having arrived, the Commander-in-Chief resolved to storm the formidable entrenchments of the Sikhs at *Sobraon*, and finally expel them from the territory they had invaded. This was an undertaking of some magnitude. It was ascertained that the entrenchments were defended by thirty thousand of their bravest troops; besides being united by a good bridge to a reserve on the opposite bank of the river, on which was stationed a considerable camp, with artillery, which commanded and flanked their field-works on the British side of the Sutlej.

On the 10th of February the FIFTY-THIRD formed part of the attacking division, on the extreme left of the army, under the command of Major-General Sir Robert Dick. It had been intended that the cannonade should have commenced at daybreak, but the heavy mist, which hung over the field and river, rendered it necessary to delay operations until the sun's rays had cleared the atmosphere. Meanwhile, on the margin of the Sutlej, two brigades of Major-General Sir Robert Dick's division, under his personal command, stood ready to commence the assault against the extreme right of the Sikhs. His seventh brigade, in which was the tenth foot, reinforced by the FIFTY-THIRD regiment, and led by Brigadier Stacy, was to head the attack, supported at two hundred yards distance by the sixth brigade under Brigadier Wilkinson.

The part the FIFTY-THIRD sustained in the conflict cannot be better expressed than in the words of the despatch of the Commander-in-Chief, General Sir Hugh Gough:—

"At nine o'clock, Brigadier Stacy's brigade, supported on either flank by Captains Horseford's and Fordyce's batteries, and Lieut.-Colonel Lane's troop of horse artillery, moved to the attack in admirable order. The infantry and guns aided each other correlatively. The former marched steadily on in line, which they halted only to correct when necessary. The latter took up successive positions at the gallop, until at length they were within three hundred yards of the heavy batteries of the Sikhs; but notwithstanding the regularity and coolness, and scientific character of this assault, which

Brigadier Wilkinson well supported, so hot was the fire of cannon, musketry, and zumboorucks kept up by the Khalsa troops, that it seemed for some moments impossible that the entrenchments could be won under it; but soon persevering gallantry triumphed, and the whole army had the satisfaction to see the gallant Brigadier Stacy's soldiers driving the Sikhs in confusion before them within the area of their encampment. The tenth foot, under Lieut.-Colonel Franks, now for the first time brought into serious contact with the enemy, greatly distinguished themselves. This regiment never fired a shot until it had got within the works of the enemy. *The onset of Her Majesty's FIFTY-THIRD was as gallant and effective.* The forty-third and fifty-ninth native infantry, brigaded with them, emulated both in cool determination."

Allusion was also made to the FIFTY-THIRD in the General Order of the 14th of February, by the Right Honorable the Governor-General of India, in which it was stated:—

"Her Majesty's tenth, FIFTY-THIRD, and eightieth regiments, with the thirty-third, forty-third, fifty-ninth, and sixty-third native infantry, moving at a firm and steady pace, *never fired a shot till they had passed the barriers opposed to them*, a forbearance much to be commended, and most worthy of constant imitation, to which may be attributed *the success of their effort, and the small loss they sustained.*"

The first success was gallantly seconded by the remainder of the army, and by eleven o'clock, after a severe hand-to-hand conflict, the *Battle of Sobraon* was gained. A sudden rise of the Sutlej rendered the river hardly fordable, and added to the loss of the Sikhs' numbers of whom were drowned in attempting the passage. Sixty-seven pieces of cannon, upwards of two hundred camel-swivels (zumboorucks), numerous standards, and vast munitions of war were the trophies of the victory.

Captain Charles Edward Dawson Warren, and eight rank and file of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment, were killed. Lieutenant-Colonel William George Gold, Captain Thomas Smart, Lieutenants John Chester, Anthony B. O. Stokes, Robert Nathaniel Clarke, and John Breton, Ensigns Henry Lucas and William Dunning (Adjutant) were wounded. Captain Smart and Lieutenant Clarke died in a few days of their wounds. Lieutenant Dunning, who was promoted after the battle, also died of his wound on the 6th of

April following. One serjeant and one hundred and four rank and file were wounded.

Medals were struck for the victories of *Aliwal* and *Sobraon*, and were presented by the Government of India to the regiments present in those battles.

Her Majesty has been graciously pleased to authorize the FIFTY-THIRD regiment to bear on its colours and appointments the words "ALIWAL" and "SOBRAON," to commemorate its gallantry in those victories.

The Battle of Sobraon concluded a campaign of unexampled rapidity, and the youthful Sovereign of Lahore, Maha Rajah Dhuleep Singh, was compelled to wait upon the Right Honorable the Governor-General, Sir Henry Hardinge, and express contrition for the offences of his army for the unjust and unprovoked invasion of the British territories. The Maha Rajah was afterwards conducted to his capital by the British troops, who formally took possession of the citadel of Lahore. In less than two months, four important victories had been gained on a line of country about sixty miles in length, under most trying circumstances, over a great and warlike people, possessed of military skill of no common order, with all the appliances of war, which will ever render the campaign one of the most remarkable in the History of India, a campaign in which the Governor-General, Sir Henry (now Viscount) Hardinge, was present in the several actions, volunteering to act as second in command, that he might aid the admirable strategy of the Commander-in-chief General Sir Hugh (now Lord) Gough, by his presence and military experience.

The regiment marched from Sobraon on the 11th of February, forming part of the advance guard of the army proceeding to Lahore, where it arrived on the 13th of that month, and encamped outside its walls until the 22nd of March, when the regiment received orders to march for Umballa, which it commenced on the following day, arriving there and entering the cantonments on the 8th of April, 1846.

On the 15th of October, 1846, the regiment proceeded to Ferozepore, and arrived there on the 28th of that month.

The regiment remained in cantonments at Ferozepore during the year 1847.

1848

On the 21st of February, 1848, the regiment returned to Lahore, where it was stationed in December, 1848, to which period this record of the services of the regiment is brought.

1848.

FOOTNOTES:

[6] In December, 1755, eleven regiments of infantry were raised, which have been since retained on the Establishment of the Army, and are numbered from the 50th to the 60th regiments inclusive.

[7] The spirited conduct of this brigade, on several occasions when engaged with the enemy, had given it the appellation of the "*Fighting Brigade*."

[8] Jones's Journal of the Campaign of 1794.

[9] Captain Brisbane, now General Sir Thomas Brisbane, G.C.B., commanded the light company on this occasion, which consisted of 33 men, of whom 22 were killed or wounded.

[10] Return showing the number of officers and soldiers who died, or were killed in action, with those invalided, from 1805 to 1822.

Year	Killed and Died.		Invalided	Year	Killed and Died.		Invalided
	Officers	Soldiers			Officers	Soldiers	
1805	1	39	..	1815	1	90	54
1806	1	109	..	1816	1	53	29
1807	.	49	45	1817	3	111	57
1808	1	77	17	1818	10	103	45
1809	.	56	13	1819	2	64	35
1810	1	32	21	1820	4	80	43
1811	.	28	17	1821	2	38	28
1812	5	75	45	1822	1	50	..
1813	1	33	21		—	—	—
1814	1	80	15	Total	35	1167	485

[11] The five rivers, which intersect the *Punjaub*, from which circumstance the country derives its name, are the *Indus*, *Chenaub*, *Jhelum*, *Ravee*, and *Sutlej*.

[12] Thus named after General Avitabile, one of the military instructors of the Sikhs. He was a native of Italy, and, at the conclusion of Napoleon's bright but evanescent career, sought employment in the East. Peshawur, at the period when he was elevated governor, was in a state of anarchy, but by his vigorous administration was reduced to a state of comparative security. He was handsomely rewarded by the Sovereign of the Punjaub, Runjeet Singh, for his exertions, along with another Italian officer, named Ventura, and two Frenchmen, Allard and Court, for introducing European tactics into the Sikh

army. After completing his task, he returned to Europe, for the purpose of ending his days on his native soil, but at this period was still alive; and is said to have congratulated himself on the brave stand the Sikhs made, attributable in a great degree to his instructions. The other European officers, Allard, Court, and Ventura, are dead.



Madeley lith. 3 Wellington S. Strand

FIFTY THIRD REGIMENT.
 QUEENS COLOUR.
 REGIMENTAL COLOUR.

For Cannon's Military Records

HISTORICAL RECORD
OF THE SERVICES OF THE
SECOND BATTALION
OF
THE FIFTY-THIRD,
OR
THE SHROPSHIRE REGIMENT OF FOOT.

1803

A short interval from war was ceded to Europe by the peace of Amiens, and during that period the First Consul of France, Napoleon Bonaparte, was secretly making hostile preparations for accomplishing his ambitious purposes; he assumed the position of a dictator to Europe, and when the British government refused to submit to his domination, he assembled an army for the invasion of England, that he might, by one mighty effort, destroy the power of the British people, who appeared as a barrier to his schemes of aggrandizement. The spirit of the nation was aroused by the menace of invasion; patriotic enthusiasm pervaded all ranks; and the "*Army of Reserve Act*" having been passed for raising men for home service by ballot, the FIFTY-THIRD regiment marched into Yorkshire to receive part of the men raised in that extensive county. The numbers received being considerable, a second battalion was added to the establishment in October, 1803, and was formed at Sunderland under the superintendence of Lieut.-Colonel Scrogs; it speedily mustered one thousand rank and file.

1804

A number of the men, raised under the provision of the Army of Reserve Act, having voluntarily extended their services, they were added to the first battalion in February, 1804; the others, being only liable to serve in the United Kingdom, remained in the second battalion, which embarked from Whitehaven for Dublin, where it arrived on the 3rd of March, under the orders of Lieut.-Colonel Lightburn. In August it encamped on the Curragh of Kildare, and in September returned to Dublin.

1805

The battalion was conspicuous for its good conduct while at Dublin; in July of this year it marched to Galway, under the command of Lieut.-Colonel Bingham. The Commander-in-Chief in Ireland, Lieut.-General Lord Cathcart, proceeding with a body of troops to Hanover, he was so highly esteemed by the FIFTY-THIRD, that the men solicited their commanding officer to forward a memorial to head-quarters, requesting permission to extend their services to the Continent, and to accompany his Lordship. They were thanked for their spirited offer; but the circumstances of the service did not require their presence on the Continent at this period. During the winter the battalion marched to Limerick.

1806

In March, 1806, the head-quarters were removed to Rathkeale: in April two hundred men proceeded to join the first battalion in India: they were followed by a further number of three hundred in October: as this detachment was proceeding to the Isle of Wight, one transport was boarded by a French privateer; the soldiers were without arms, otherwise they could have overpowered their enemies: Captain Classen and sixty-five men were taken to France, where the captain died.

1807

During the winter of 1807 the limited-service men of the second battalion were transferred to a garrison battalion, which greatly reduced its numbers; the few remaining men marched to Dublin in January, 1807, embarked from thence for Liverpool, and afterward proceeded to Shrewsbury.

1808

The second battalion proceeded from Shrewsbury to Weymouth, where it arrived in October, and was joined by a number of volunteers from the militia.

In the spring of 1808 the second battalion marched to Bletchington; in May was removed to Portsmouth, where it embarked for Ireland, and after landing at Cork, it proceeded from thence to Limerick, and in the autumn to Fermoy.

1809

At this period the second battalion received orders to proceed from Ireland, to take part in the deliverance of the Peninsula from the power of Napoleon, Emperor of France, whose attempts to subvert the liberties of Europe were strenuously opposed by Great Britain. The battalion embarked at Cork on the 12th of March, landed in Portugal, at a small town opposite Lisbon, on the 6th of April; and proceeded up the river Tagus in boats a few days afterwards to Villa Franca, from whence it marched to Rio Mayor. The seventh Royal fusiliers, and the FIFTY-THIRD, were formed in brigade under Brigadier-General A. Campbell; and the officers and soldiers were highly gratified by the arrival of Lieut.-General Sir Arthur Wellesley to assume the command of the army.

The FIFTY-THIRD had the honor of taking part in the operations by which the French army under Marshal Soult was driven from *Oporto*: they were not engaged in forcing the passage of the Douro on the 12th of May; they had completed a short march and were going into billets at Cavalhos, when the order to advance arrived, and the soldiers evinced their ardour by cheerfully performing a long march at double quick time, and they were speedily across the river; but the action had ceased, and they went into quarters in the city of *Oporto*, after a march of twenty-eight miles.

After taking part in the pursuit of the French army through mountainous districts to the confines of Portugal, the FIFTY-THIRD retired to *Oporto*, where they halted one day; they afterwards proceeded to Coimbra, and in the early part of June to Abrantes.

Advancing into Spain, the FIFTY-THIRD shared in the operations which preceded the battle of *Talavera*, and suffered, in common with other corps, great privation from the want of supplies, the soldiers having no food, on

many occasions, excepting corn gathered from the fields. In the action on the 28th of July, two companies of the FIFTY-THIRD particularly distinguished themselves: the other companies of the battalion were in reserve in the first instance; but they were brought forward, and assailing one of the enemy's columns of attack in flank, they greatly contributed to its discomfiture and overthrow, when thirteen pieces of artillery were captured. Sir Arthur Wellesley saw, from a hill at a short distance, the fighting at this part of the field, and sent twice to testify his approbation of the conduct of the brigade. The French were repulsed at all points; and the word "TALavera," on the colours of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment, commemorates the gallantry of the second battalion on this occasion: its loss was six soldiers killed; Major Kingscote, Captain Stawell, and twenty-nine rank and file wounded.

The following officers were at the battle of Talavera, on the 27th and 28th of July, 1809:—

Lieut.-Colonel G. R. Bingham. *Majors* W. Thursby and N. Kingscote. *Captains* H. Parker, John Robinson, O. G. Fehrszen, and J. L. Stawell. *Lieutenants* J. B. Glew, Charles Ribs, F. H. Fuller, D. Beatty, P. Hovenden, and C. Williams. *Ensigns* Edward Barlow, George Langton, G. C. Goff, Joseph Nicholson, J. Christie, J. J. C. Harrison, H. Brown, and J. Devenish. *Adjutant* John Carss. *Surgeon* J. Sandall. *Assistant-Surgeon* J. Dunn. *Quarter-Master*—Blackie.

The immense superiority of numbers which the French were enabled to bring forward at this period, prevented those decisive results following the victory at Talavera which might have been anticipated: the army withdrew behind the Tagus, and subsequently occupied a position on the Guadiana river, where many soldiers, whose strength had been exhausted by long marches under a hot sun and a scanty supply of provisions, died. In the autumn the battalion went into quarters at Olivença, and in December commenced its march across the country to Guarda in Portugal, where it arrived on the 11th of January, 1810.

1810

In the beginning of March, 1810, the second battalion was removed from Guarda to several pleasant villages in the valley of the Mondego, where the health of the men quickly improved. A numerous French army, under

Marshal Massena, advanced and besieged Ciudad Rodrigo; and on the 1st of July the FIFTY-THIRD proceeded to the Coa river, to support the light division, observe the bridge of Castel Bom, and the ford of Juan Miguel. The enemy, having captured Ciudad Rodrigo, advanced in great force to invade Portugal; Lord Wellington, not having an army sufficiently numerous to oppose the French in the field, retired: the FIFTY-THIRD fell back from the Coa upon Guarda, and afterwards withdrew gradually before the enemy, until it arrived at the rugged rocks of *Busaco*, where the French legions found their advance impeded by a formidable line of British bayonets. The FIFTY-THIRD were detached a short distance to the left, to observe a small mountain road which came round that flank of the position, and during the action on the 27th of September their post was not attacked. The French, being unable to force the position, turned it by a flank movement; and the British retreated to the fortified lines of *Torres Vedras*, where they opposed a front of battle which the French did not venture to attack; but, after reconnoitring the lines fell back to Santarem, where they remained during the winter.

1811

In Portugal the opposing armies confronted each other until the 5th of March, when the French, having lost many men, and being unable to procure provisions, made a sudden retreat towards the frontiers of Portugal. The FIFTY-THIRD followed the retreating enemy—several skirmishes occurred; and towards the end of March the battalion went into quarters at the hamlet of Romilioza, in the valley of the Mondego.

Again advancing on the 2nd of April, the battalion approached the river Coa on the following day, when the French were driven from the vicinity of Sabugal. Four days afterwards it proceeded to Castel Bom; and on the 9th of April covered a reconnoissance, made by Colonel Fletcher of the Royal Engineers, on the fortress of *Almeida*, which was invested two days afterwards, when the FIFTY-THIRD took post on the east side of the town. They afterwards moved to San Pedro, and furnished piquets before the fortress.

When Marshal Massena advanced to raise the blockade of Almeida, the FIFTY-THIRD quitted San Pedro and took their station in the position near *Fuentes d'Onor*. The attacks of the enemy on the 3rd of May were repulsed;

on the 5th they were renewed, and the FIFTY-THIRD advanced to support the piquets, which were engaged among some stone fences to the left of the village. As it advanced, the battalion was exposed to the fire of a French battery, but did not sustain any loss: it took post at the foot of a hill, and supported the piquets until the action ceased: the French being repulsed, they afterwards retreated.

The FIFTY-THIRD resumed their post before Almeida; but the French garrison contrived to destroy the works and guns of the fortress, and to effect its escape during the night of the 11th of May.

When the siege of Badajoz occasioned the advance of Marshal Marmont with the French army to Spanish Estremadura, the FIFTY-THIRD, and other corps left on the Agueda, made a corresponding movement, and joined the army under Lord Wellington in the Alemtejo. The French armies separating again, the FIFTY-THIRD returned, with the sixth division, of which they formed part, to the northern frontiers of Portugal. On the 11th of September the battalion crossed the Agueda river to the small village of Felicio Chico, to protect the inhabitants from the depredations of the garrison of Ciudad Rodrigo. A numerous French army advancing to throw a supply into that fortress, the FIFTY-THIRD withdrew across the river, and proceeded to Fuentes d'Onor; from whence they moved to the vicinity of Espejo. The French forces advancing, the allies, being much inferior in numbers, withdrew a few stages; the enemy soon retired again, and the FIFTY-THIRD went into village cantonments.

Major-General Campbell, being appointed to the staff of the army in India, took leave of the sixth division, in an order dated the 5th of November, and after expressing his thanks to the general officers commanding brigades, and officers commanding regiments, he adverted "to his feelings of regret at being about to separate from that brigade which it was so long his pride to command, and especially from the FIFTY-THIRD regiment, the only remaining corps of his original brigade, whose undaunted steadiness and gallantry, under the command of Lieut.-Colonel Bingham, gained them the admiration of the army the first time they were under fire."

In January, 1812, when Lord Wellington besieged and captured *Ciudad Rodrigo*, the sixth division was at Penna Verde; but it advanced to the frontiers on the approach of the French army: when the enemy withdrew, the FIFTY-THIRD fell back to Grajal. They subsequently traversed the country to Elvas, and formed part of the covering army during the siege of *Badajoz*, which fortress was captured by storm on the 6th of April. After taking an active part in the operations of the covering army, the FIFTY-THIRD again marched northward, and halted at Castel de Vide on the 2nd of May.

The services of the second battalion in Portugal and Spain, had been equally meritorious with those of the first battalion in India. After returning from Spanish Estremadura, it reposed a short period in quarters: in May it moved forward to support the troops under Lieut.-General Hill in their attack on the French bridge at *Almaraz*, and afterwards returned to Castel de Vide.

In June the army passed the Agueda river and advanced to *Salamanca*, the French retiring upon Toro, but leaving a body of troops in two *fortified convents*. The FIFTY-THIRD were employed in the siege of these convents, and on the 18th of June Lieutenant J. H. Devenish was severely wounded in the trenches; he died on the 24th, and was buried in the church near the great square of the city. Marshal Marmont advancing to relieve the besieged convents, the regiment was twice removed from the siege to confront the French army; but the enemy did not hazard an attack. On the 23rd of June, when an unsuccessful attempt was made by the light infantry to capture the smaller convent by escalade, the regiment had three men killed; Lieutenant James Hamilton, and seven men, wounded. The progress of the siege was delayed by a scarcity of ammunition, but a supply was received. The smaller convent was captured by storm on the 27th of June; and the attack on the larger one had commenced, when the commandant surrendered.

Advancing from Salamanca the army proceeded to the banks of the Douro; but the French having been considerably reinforced, and having crossed that river, the allies fell back to the vicinity of Salamanca, where the two armies manœuvred on the 22nd of July, and the enemy, having weakened his centre in his attempt to turn the right flank of the allied army, Lord Wellington seized the favourable opportunity to commence the battle. The FIFTY-THIRD, with the other corps of the sixth division, supported the fourth division in its attack on the French army, and circumstances occurred

which occasioned the regiment to be brought into action before the other corps of its division. The FIFTY-THIRD supported the twenty-third Portuguese regiment; and this corps giving way, the FIFTY-THIRD had to sustain the attack of a superior body of infantry supported by cavalry in front, at the same time they were exposed to the flank fire of the French posted on one of the hills called the Arapiles. The regiment withdrew from this unequal contest in good order, and forming square, resisted the charge of the French cavalry with great steadiness, thus affording an example of what can be effected by a small body of infantry, when charged by very superior numbers of cavalry. The officer at the head of the French dragoons having been wounded close to the bayonets of the square, and the success of the attack of the other regiments of the brigade to which the FIFTY-THIRD belonged becoming evident, the French cavalry retired, taking with them Captain Fehrszen and nine wounded men as prisoners. Lieut.-Colonel Bingham having been severely wounded, the command of the regiment devolved on Brevet Lieut.-Colonel John Mansel.

After resisting the charge of the French cavalry, the FIFTY-THIRD again advanced, and were engaged in the attack of the last position occupied by the enemy on that memorable day. This was a desperate musketry action in the dark, and the difficulties of the ascent of the mountain gave the French division, under General Maucune, formed on the summit, a decided advantage. The FIFTY-THIRD were on the left of the sixth division on this occasion, and the British gallantly won their way upwards, and finally forced the enemy to make a precipitate retreat.

Colonel Napier has given the following spirited description of this last attack, in his History of the Peninsular War:—"Assisted by a brigade of the fourth division, the troops then rushed up, and in the darkness of the night the fire showed from afar how the battle went. On the side of the British a sheet of flame was seen, sometimes advancing with an even front, sometimes pricking forth in spear heads, now falling back in waving lines, and anon darting upwards in one vast pyramid, the apex of which often approached, yet never gained, the actual summit of the mountain; but the French musketry, rapid as lightning, sparkled along the brow of the height with unvarying fulness, and with what desperate effects, the dark gaps and changing shapes of the adverse fire showed too plainly. Yet, when Pakenham had again turned the enemy's left, and Foy's division had glided

into the forest, Maucune's task was completed, the effulgent crest of the ridge became black and silent, and the French army vanished, as it were, into darkness."

The French army was overpowered and driven from the field with severe loss: and the Royal authority was afterwards given for the FIFTY-THIRD regiment to bear the word "SALAMANCA" on its colours, to commemorate the distinguished conduct of the second battalion on this memorable occasion: Lieut.-Colonel Bingham and Lieut.-Colonel Mansel received gold medals.

Nineteen men were killed. *Captain* A. K. Blackhall died of his wounds, much regretted; *Lieut.-Colonel* Bingham, *Brevet Lieut.-Colonel* Robertson, *Captains* O. G. Fehrszen, J. W. Poppleton, D. M'Dougall, and John Fernandez, *Lieutenants* J. B. Hunter, and Joseph Nicholson, *Ensign* Peter Bunworth, *Adjutant* John Carss, *Volunteer* Munro Morphet, and seventy-six men were wounded; nine men wounded and prisoners. Captain Fehrszen was taken prisoner, but was left by the enemy at Alba de Tormes. The total loss amounted to nearly half the soldiers under arms on this occasion.

The following officers were in the field, and escaped uninjured:—*Lieut.-Colonel* John Mansel. *Lieutenants* P. Hovenden, and John Fraser. *Ensigns* W. Harrison, W. Baxter, George Fitzgerald, Robert Hilliard, J. W. Moir, and Michael Nagle. *Surgeon* T. Sandell; *Assistant-Surgeon* Charles MacLean.

On the day after the battle, Major-General Hulse was nominated to command the fifth division, when the command of the brigade devolved on Lieut.-Colonel Mansel of the FIFTY-THIRD, and that of the second battalion of the regiment on Lieutenant Hovenden. In August Lieut.-Colonel Bingham was sufficiently recovered of his wounds to resume his duty, when he took the command of the brigade, and Lieut.-Colonel Mansel that of the second battalion of the regiment.

Advancing in pursuit of the enemy, the army entered the city of Valladolid amidst the rejoicings of the people. The FIFTY-THIRD were afterwards left, with the sixth division, at the small town of Cuellar, in the province of Segovia, while Lord Wellington advanced with the army to Madrid. General Clauzel returning with the re-organized French army, the sixth division withdrew to Arevalo. Lord Wellington returning from Madrid, the French again retreated, and the allied army advanced up the beautiful Pisuerga and Arlanzan valleys, turning the enemy's positions and

forcing him to continue his retreat beyond Burgos. The FIFTY-THIRD were employed in the siege of the castle of *Burgos*, in which service they had four men killed, Ensign Nagle, one serjeant, and several men wounded. Lieutenant Fraser distinguished himself at the attack of one of the out-works. The concentration of the enemy's numerous forces having rendered a retrograde movement necessary, the FIFTY-THIRD shared in the fatigues, privations, and sufferings of the retreat from Burgos to the frontiers of Portugal, where they went into winter-quarters; they were removed from the sixth to the fourth division, and formed in brigade with the third battalion of the twenty-seventh, and the first battalions of the fortieth and forty-eighth regiments, under Major-General William Anson.

1813

The second battalion having become considerably reduced in numbers by its arduous services in Spain and Portugal, the effective and efficient soldiers were formed into four companies, for service in the Peninsula; and the officers of the other six companies, with the remaining non-commissioned officers and soldiers, were ordered to proceed to England, under the command of Captain Poppleton. The four service companies marched to join the head-quarters of the fourth division, at St. Jaõ de Pesqueira, where they arrived on the 6th of January, and were formed with four companies of the second, or the Queen's Royal, into the second provisional battalion, which was commanded by Lieut.-Colonel Bingham of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment.

Taking the field under a superior organization strengthened by reinforcements, and proudly confident in the skill and resources of its commander, the allied army penetrated Spain in May, to turn the French positions on the Douro. The FIFTY-THIRD formed part of the force under Lieut.-General Sir Thomas Graham (afterwards Lord Lynedoch), which proceeded through the mountainous regions of the *Tras-os-Montes*, and passed the *Esla* river, the French falling back on *Toro*. Pressing forward upon their numerous enemies, the British forced them to quit one position after another, until the legions of France were concentrated in the plain of *Vittoria*, under Joseph Bonaparte, titular King of Spain, where they prepared to oppose the victorious career of the allied army. In the battle of the 21st of June the FIFTY-THIRD formed part of the centre column, under the

immediate command of Lord Wellington, and their bearing throughout the day, which ended in the complete overthrow and discomfiture of the French army, was afterwards rewarded with the Royal authority to bear the word "VITTORIA" on the colours of the regiment. Their loss was four men killed and six wounded.

The following officers served at the battle of Vittoria,—viz.:

Colonel G. R. Bingham. *Captains* O. G. Fehrszen and James Mackay. *Lieutenants* C. F. Hunter, Thomas Impett, James Hamilton, Thomas Dowker, and John Fraser. *Ensigns* George Fitzgerald, Michael Nagle, and John Wilton. *Adjutant* John Carss. *Surgeon* Thomas Sandell; *Assistant-Surgeon* Charles MacLean. Volunteer John Fernandez.

From the field of battle the FIFTY-THIRD followed the rear of the defeated French army to the vicinity of Pampeluna, and were afterwards employed in the attempt to intercept General Clauzel's French division, which had not been at the battle of Vittoria: this body of troops having escaped by the pass of Jaca, the FIFTY-THIRD were employed in the blockade of Pampeluna; but were relieved by the Spaniards in the middle of July, and advanced into the Pyrenean mountains, where they were stationed in support of the troops occupying the head of the pass of Roncesvalles.

When the French army under Marshal Soult advanced to resume offensive operations, the allied army retired to a position in the *Pyrenees* in front of Pampeluna, where some severe fighting took place, and the repeated attacks of the French were repulsed. Speaking of the action on the 28th of July, Lord Wellington stated—"In the course of this contest, the fourth division, which has so frequently been distinguished in this army, surpassed its former good conduct." On the 30th of July the FIFTY-THIRD regiment had an opportunity of distinguishing itself, during the severely contested action in the mountains; and the light infantry, commanded by Captain FEHRSEN, of the FIFTY-THIRD, signalized themselves in a particular manner. The meritorious conduct of Captain FEHRSEN was rewarded with the rank of major. The French were driven from their post, and pursued to their own frontiers: and the word "PYRENEES" on the colours of the regiment commemorates the heroic conduct of the officers and soldiers of the second battalion on this occasion. Their loss was three men killed and twenty-one wounded.

The following officers served at the battle of the Pyrenees:—

Lieut.-Colonel G. R. BINGHAM. *Captains* O. G. Fehrszen and James Mackay. *Lieutenants* C. F. Hunter, Thomas Impett, James Hamilton, and Thos. Dowker. *Ensigns* George Fitzgerald, Michael Nagle, and John Wilton. *Pay-Master* J. MacLean. *Adjutant* John Carss. *Quarter-Master* R. Blackie. *Surgeon* T. Sandall. *Assistant-Surgeon* C. MacLean.

Pursuing the French army through the mountains, the FIFTY-THIRD captured some prisoners and baggage, and arrived at Puerto de Echalar on the 2nd of August, when Major-General Barnes's brigade was engaged with two French divisions, which it drove from the heights. Five days afterwards the FIFTY-THIRD were removed to the vicinity of Lezaca, where the headquarters of the allied army were established; from this place a few volunteers of the FIFTY-THIRD proceeded to *St. Sebastian*, and were engaged in storming that fortress on the 31st of August, when two men of the regiment were killed and two wounded. On the same day the French crossed the Bidassoa in considerable force, and attacked the Spanish troops on the heights of San Marcial. On this occasion the FIFTY-THIRD were engaged in extended order in the pass of *St. Antonio*, where they had one man killed and twenty wounded. The French were repulsed, and giving up all hope of being able to relieve *St. Sebastian*, they re-crossed the river.

At the passage of the *Bidassoa* on the 7th of October, the FIFTY-THIRD supported the light division; and during the action on the following day they were in reserve.

Looking down from the lofty Pyrenees on the well guarded territory of France, the British Commander prepared to carry the war into the heart of that kingdom, and on the morning of the 10th of November his conquering divisions traversed the mountain passes by moonlight, to attack the enemy's fortified position on the *Nivelle*. The FIFTY-THIRD carried bags filled with fern, to fill up the ditch, and small ladders to mount the rampart of a redoubt, which they were directed to take. Advancing under the cover of a heavy cannonade, the soldiers raised a loud and confident shout, as they approached the redoubt, when the French fired a few shots and fled. The redoubt was taken possession of, and about thirty of the enemy, who had not time to escape, were made prisoners. The British were successful at every point, and the French made a retreat. During the action Major

FEHRSEN had an opportunity of making a sudden dash with a few men, and he succeeded in capturing a field gun. For their gallant services on this occasion the FIFTY-THIRD were rewarded with the Royal authority to bear the word "NIVELLE" on their colours, in addition to the other inscriptions previously acquired.

One serjeant and three private soldiers were killed; Major Fehrszen, Captain Mackay, Lieutenant Hamilton, and a few private soldiers wounded.

Names of officers who served at the battle of Nivelle:—

Lieut.-Colonel G. R. Bingham. *Major* O. G. Fehrszen. *Captains* James Mackay and John Carss. *Lieutenants* C. F. Hunter, Tho. Impett, Tho. Dowker, James Hamilton, and John Fraser. *Ensigns* George Fitzgerald and M. Nagle. *Adjutant* John Wilton. *Assistant-Surgeons* James Dunn and Charles MacLean.

At the passage of the Nive river, on the 9th of December, and in the actions which followed, the FIFTY-THIRD were in reserve, and did not sustain any loss: they subsequently went into cantonments during the severe weather which followed.

Some movements were made by the FIFTY-THIRD in the early part of January, 1814; and on the 6th of that month they advanced to attack a body of French troops; but were prevented engaging by a brook, the stream of which was so swollen by the rains as to be impassable. The battalion was afterwards stationed at Ustaritz, where it remained until the middle of February, when active operations were commenced against the French army. After taking part in several movements, the FIFTY-THIRD marched to St. Jean de Luz, where they arrived on the 22nd of February, and were supplied with new clothing at that place.

On the 25th of February the FIFTY-THIRD commenced their march to re-join the army; but were not in time to take part in the battle of Orthes on the 27th of that month. They passed the Adour at St. Sever on the 3rd of March, and joined the fourth division at Grenade, where they remained a week, and afterwards marched in the direction of Bordeaux, which city was taken possession of by the troops under Marshal Beresford; the population renounced their allegiance to the Emperor Napoleon, and declared themselves in favour of the Bourbon dynasty.

In the meantime the six companies which returned to England in January, 1813, had been so successful in recruiting, and in obtaining volunteers from the militia, that they were reported fit for service, and embarked at Portsmouth on the 1st of March, 1814, to join the allied army; they landed at Passages in Spain under the orders of Lieut.-Colonel Mansel, and advancing through the mountains into France, continued their march to Tarbes, where they arrived on the 30th of March, and were halted for the purpose of carrying on operations against the castle of *L'Ourde*, which remained in the possession of the enemy. Lieut.-Colonel Mansel joined the army and took the command of the second provisional battalion, Lieut.-Colonel Bingham having returned to England on leave of absence about two months previously.

The four companies of the FIFTY-THIRD, forming part of the second provisional battalion, had been withdrawn from the road to Bordeaux, and proceeded to the vicinity of *Toulouse*, where Marshal Soult had assembled the French army to arrest the progress of the allies, who did not receive the news of the abdication of Napoleon until the 12th of April. Marshal Soult's position was attacked on the 10th of April, on which occasion the four companies formed part of the force which turned the enemy's right, and carried the heights on that flank. On ascending the heights, the second provisional battalion encountered a French brigade, in column, which was soon routed. The enemy was driven from his positions; and the word "TOULOUSE" on the colours of the regiment commemorates the gallant bearing of the officers and soldiers of the FIFTY-THIRD on this occasion. The four companies had a few men killed and wounded; Lieutenant Hamilton died of his wounds, much regretted, being an officer of great promise. Captains Mackay and Mansel, and Lieutenant Impett, were wounded, and recovered.

Names of officers who served at the battle of Toulouse. *Lieut.-Colonel J. Mansel. Major O. G. Fehrszen. Captains J. Giles (Major), James Mackay, and R. C. Mansel. Lieutenants C. F. Hunter, J. Hamilton, Thomas Impett, J. Fraser, and G. Fitzgerald. Adjutant J. Wilton. Assistant-Surgeons J. Dunn and C. MacLean.*

Marshal Soult having retired from Toulouse, the allied army advanced a short distance beyond the town; and the six companies of the FIFTY-THIRD, from England, arrived and joined the fourth division.

Hostilities were soon afterwards terminated; the island of Elba was ceded to Napoleon Bonaparte in full sovereignty, with the imperial title for life; the Bourbon family was restored to the throne of France; and the victorious soldiers of the allied army were thus rewarded with a complete triumph over the enemies of their country. The Royal authority was afterwards given for the word "PENINSULA" to be added to the honorary inscriptions on the colours of the FIFTY-THIRD, to commemorate their meritorious services in Portugal, Spain, and the south of France, where they had fought and conquered for the welfare of Europe.

After reposing a few weeks in convenient quarters, the FIFTY-THIRD marched to the vicinity of Bordeaux, where they were encamped a short period, and received the thanks of Lieut.-General Sir Lowry Cole, commanding the fourth division, in orders;—Colonel Bingham and Lieut.-Colonel Mansel being particularly mentioned. They were also reviewed by the Marquis of Wellington, whose congratulations and expressions of approbation were communicated to the army in general orders, and they afterwards embarked for Ireland. They landed at Monkstown on the 7th of July, and marched to Kinsale, but re-embarked on the 23rd of that month, for England, and landing at Portsmouth, proceeded from thence to Hilsea barracks, where Colonel Bingham joined and assumed the command.

1815

During this period NAPOLEON BONAPARTE had returned to France, his army had been overthrown at WATERLOO, and he had surrendered himself to Captain Maitland, commanding the Bellerophon ship of war: the island of St. Helena was afterwards appointed for his future residence. The second battalion of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment, having been very successful in recruiting, was selected to accompany Bonaparte to the island named as the place of exile for this extraordinary man. The battalion embarked from Portsmouth on the 1st of August, under the command of Major Fehrszen; Colonel Sir George Bingham^[13] commanding the troops employed in this service. It arrived at St. Helena in October, and after occupying the barracks at James Town a few days, proceeded to the interior of the island, where

new barracks were constructed, and it furnished the requisite guards, piquets, and sentries for the cordon of General Bonaparte.

At this period the serjeants of the battalion, who had distinguished themselves in the Peninsula, were presented with medals to be worn on their left breasts. The medals were issued by Colonel Sir George Bingham, in compliance with directions from the colonel of the regiment, Lieut.-General Sir John Abercromby, G.C.B., and were delivered to the following serjeants:—

NAMES.	BATTLES AT WHICH THEY HAD SERVED.
John Wilton	Talavera and Salamanca.
James Mellor	Talavera, Salamanca, Vittoria, Pyrenees, Nivelle, and Toulouse.
Josh. Rushton	Talavera, Salamanca, Vittoria, Pyrenees, Nivelle, and Toulouse.
Jno. Robinson	Talavera, Vittoria, and Pyrenees.
Geo. Bannister	Salamanca, Vittoria, Pyrenees, Nivelle, and Toulouse.
Wm. Hartley	Salamanca, Vittoria, Pyrenees, Nivelle, and Toulouse.
Wm. West	Salamanca, Vittoria, Pyrenees, Nivelle, and Toulouse.
Thos. Cox	Salamanca.
Abm. Peel	Talavera and Salamanca.
Saml. Sutcliffe	Talavera, Salamanca, Vittoria, Pyrenees, Nivelle, and Toulouse.
Jas. Whitehead	Talavera, Salamanca, Vittoria, Pyrenees, Nivelle, and Toulouse.
John Whitely	Talavera, Salamanca, and Toulouse.
Wm. Brooksbank	Salamanca.
Hen. Cockroft	Talavera and Salamanca.
John Smith	Salamanca.

Serjeant Wilton was promoted to the adjutancy of the battalion; Serjeant Mellor to serjeant-major; and Serjeant Rushton to quarter-master serjeant.

1816

During this year the second battalion remained on duty at St. Helena, where it received the thanks of the Governor, Lieut.-General Sir Hudson Lowe: in May Lieut.-Colonel Mansel arrived and assumed the command.

1817

The second battalion of the FIFTY-THIRD remained on duty at St. Helena until July of this year, when the continued peace of Europe occasioning a considerable reduction in the army, it was ordered to return to England to be

disbanded. It transferred thirteen serjeants, one drummer, and two hundred and eighty-eight rank and file to the first battalion in India; and embarking from St. Helena in the middle of July, received, previous to going on board of the ship "Baring," the expression, in general orders, of the Governor's approbation and admiration of its conduct while at St. Helena. Previous to the officers of the FIFTY-THIRD quitting the island, Napoleon Bonaparte expressed a wish for them to wait on him, and the Governor having consented, they attended at the residence of Napoleon. He expressed his thankfulness for the manner in which the corps had performed the duties on which it had been employed, and for the attention and respect he had always experienced from every individual belonging to it; and also expressed his wishes for the prosperity and happiness of every member of the corps. [\[14\]](#)

On the 14th of September the second battalion arrived at Portsmouth, from whence it proceeded to join the depôt at Canterbury, where it was disbanded on the 20th of October.

1817.

FOOTNOTES:

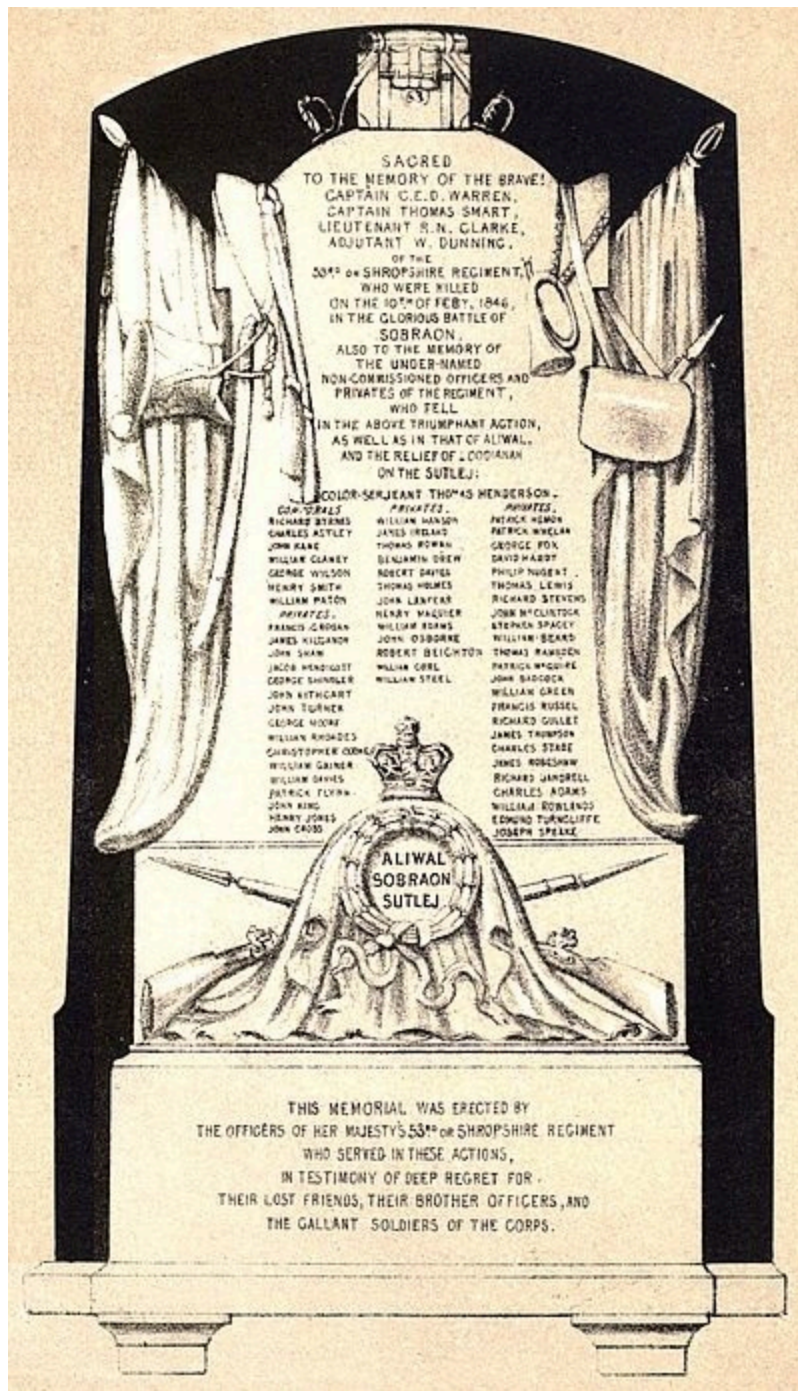
[13] See Memoir of the services of Major-General Sir George R. Bingham, K.C.B., Appendix, [page 69](#).

[14] LORD BATHURST, then Secretary of State for the Colonial Department, stated in the House of Peers, that he had heard that General BONAPARTE had spoken in terms of high approbation of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment at St. Helena, and added, "Whatsoever the General could say in praise of that corps was not adequate to its merits."

CONCLUSION.

The foregoing pages contain detailed accounts of the meritorious conduct of the first and second battalions of the *Fifty-third* regiment in Europe, as well as in Asia, and afford abundant proofs of the value of the services of the regiment, which, on numerous occasions, has received the thanks of the General Officers under whom it has served, and the approbation of the Sovereign, as testified by the marks of distinction inscribed on the Regimental Colour.

1849.



Madeley lith. 3 Wellington St. Strand.

For Cannon's Military Records

SUCCESSION OF COLONELS
OF THE
FIFTY-THIRD,
OR,
THE SHROPSHIRE REGIMENT OF FOOT.

WILLIAM WHITMORE,

Appointed 21st December, 1755.

WILLIAM WHITMORE served many years in the third foot guards; he was promoted to the rank of colonel in January, 1751; and in November, 1752, he was appointed major in his regiment. In the winter of 1755–6 he raised, formed, and disciplined a regiment of foot, now the FIFTY-THIRD, of which he was appointed colonel by commission dated the 21st of December, 1755. He was promoted to the rank of major-general in January, 1758, and removed to the ninth regiment of foot in October following. In December, 1760, he was advanced to the rank of lieut.-general. His decease occurred in 1771; at which period he was member of parliament for Portsmouth.

JOHN TOOVEY,

Appointed 5th April, 1759.

JOHN TOOVEY was a cavalry officer of reputation in the reign of King George II., and served some years in the thirteenth dragoons. In December, 1754, he was nominated to the lieut.-colonelcy of the first royal dragoons; and in April, 1759, his constant attention to all the duties of commanding officer was rewarded with the colonelcy of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment. In August, 1761, he was promoted to the rank of major-general. He died in 1770.

ROBERT DALRYMPLE HORNE ELPHINSTONE,

Appointed 5th February, 1770.

This Officer held a commission in the first, the royal regiment of foot, many years, and was promoted to the lieut.-colonelcy of the first battalion of that corps on the 20th of June, 1753. On the 3rd of August, 1762, King George III. nominated him to the colonelcy of the 120th regiment, which was raised in the beginning of that year, and disbanded in 1764. In February, 1770, he was appointed Colonel of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment; and was promoted to the rank of major-general two months afterwards. In 1777 he was advanced to the rank of lieut.-general; and in 1793 to that of general. He died in 1794.

GERARD LAKE,

Afterwards Viscount Lake,

Appointed 3rd April, 1794.

GERARD LAKE, third son of Lancelot Charles Lake, Esq., choosing the profession of arms, was nominated to the commission of ensign and lieutenant in the first foot guards, on the 9th of May, 1758; in 1762 he was promoted to lieutenant and captain, and in 1776 to captain and lieut.-colonel. He served in North America during the War of Independence; was engaged in operations in the southern states, under Major-General the Earl Cornwallis, and had opportunities of distinguishing himself. When Earl Cornwallis's force was besieged in York Town, by the united French and American armies, Lieut.-Colonel Lake commanded a detachment of foot guards and grenadiers of the eightieth regiment, which made a sortie on the 16th of October, 1781, forced the entrenchments, spiked eleven heavy guns, and killed and wounded about a hundred French soldiers. On the surrender of York Town he became a prisoner of war; but hostilities were terminated soon afterwards, and he returned to England; having been promoted to the rank of colonel in February, 1782. In 1784 he was nominated major, and in 1792 lieut.-colonel in the first foot guards. In 1790 he was advanced to the rank of major-general. On the breaking out of the French revolutionary war, he was nominated to the command of the brigade of foot guards which proceeded to Flanders, and served under His Royal Highness the Duke of York. He commanded this brigade at the battle of Famars, and at the siege

of Valenciennes; and highly distinguished himself at Lincelles, on the 18th of August, 1793, for which he was thanked in general orders. He also served before Dunkirk, and in other operations: and in 1794 he was rewarded with the colonelcy of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment, and the government of Limerick: he was afterwards nominated governor of Dumbarton. In 1796 he was removed to the seventy-third regiment: in 1797 he was promoted to the rank of lieut.-general, and placed on the staff of Ireland, where he evinced talent and energy in suppressing the rebellion which broke out in 1798, and gained several important victories over the insurgents. When the French landed in Ireland, he was obliged to retire a short distance; but additional troops advancing to his aid, he intercepted the French soldiers and forced them to surrender prisoners of war. In 1800 he was appointed Commander-in-Chief in India, and colonel of the eightieth regiment; and in 1802 he was promoted to the rank of general. He arrived in India at the period when the Governor-General, the Marquis Wellesley, was displaying the energies of his mind in counteracting the intrigues of France among the native powers of Hindoostan; and the ambitious designs of the Mahratta chiefs soon called General LAKE into the field, when his talents were conspicuously displayed. His spirited and judicious operations at Coel, on the 29th of August, 1803; the assault of Aly Ghur, on the 9th of September; and the overthrow of the Mahratta army near Delhi, on the 11th of September, on which occasion his charger was killed under him, produced decisive results. The country between the Ganges and Jumna rivers, called the Doab (a general name in India for the space between two rivers), became subject to British authority; and six days afterwards General Lake visited the Emperor, Shah Alum, whom he had rescued from oppression, and who conferred upon him titles which signified,—The Saver of the State,—Hero of the Land,—Lord of the Age,—and the Victorious in War.

Afterwards proceeding to Agra, General Lake speedily captured that place, and on the 1st of November he gained an important victory at Leswaree, when the French-officered battalions of Dowlat Rao Scindia were annihilated, the Mahratta army overpowered, and its colours, artillery, and baggage captured. His services on this occasion were of a distinguished character; he led the charge of the cavalry in the morning;—conducted in person the attacks of the infantry, and in the midst of the storm of battle he displayed valour, professional ability, promptitude, and decision; his

magnanimous example inspired confidence and emulation in the troops, and they triumphed over very superior numbers. Two horses were killed under him on this occasion.

His important services were rewarded, in 1804, with the title of LORD LAKE OF DELHI AND LESWAREE.

Pursuing the war with vigour, LORD LAKE routed the power of Holkar at Furruckabad; but the war was protracted by the defection of the Rajah of Bhurtpore; and when his Lordship besieged the city of Bhurtpore, he failed in capturing the place from the want of a battering-train. The Rajah of Bhurtpore was, however, brought to terms; and Lord Lake pursued the hostile Rajah of Berar from place to place, until this chief was brought to submission. The British military power in the East was strengthened by these successes, and the extent and stability of the dominions in India increased.

His Lordship returned to England, and in 1807 he was advanced to the dignity of VISCOUNT LAKE.

He caught cold while sitting on the general court-martial which tried Major-General Whitelocke; and died on the 30th of February, 1808.

WELBORE ELLIS DOYLE,

Appointed 2nd November, 1796.

This Officer served in the army during the American war, and on the 21st of March, 1782, he was appointed lieut.-colonel of the 105th regiment of foot, then newly raised by Francis Lord Rawdon. This corps was disbanded at the termination of the American war; and in 1789 he was nominated to the lieut.-colonelcy of the fourteenth foot, at the head of which regiment he distinguished himself in Flanders under His Royal Highness the Duke of York. He was promoted to the rank of colonel in 1793, and to that of major-general in 1795; in 1796 he was nominated colonel of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment. He died in 1798.

CHARLES CROSBIE,

Appointed 3rd January, 1798.

CHARLES CROSBIE was appointed captain in the eighty-sixth regiment on the 24th of August, 1759, and he served with this corps on the coast of Africa, being stationed some time at Senegal. He was promoted to the rank of major, and afterwards to that of lieut.-colonel in the eighty-sixth, which regiment was disbanded after the termination of the seven years' war. In 1778 he was nominated lieut.-colonel of the sixty-seventh regiment; was promoted to the rank of colonel in 1780, and to that of major-general in 1787. In 1794 he was nominated colonel of the Royal Dublin regiment of foot, which was embodied at that period, and disbanded soon afterwards. He was appointed colonel of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment in January, 1797, and promoted to the rank of lieut.-general in December following; in 1802 he was promoted to the rank of general. He died on the 18th of March, 1807.

THE HONORABLE JOHN ABERCROMBY,

Appointed 21st March, 1807.

JOHN ABERCROMBY was the second son of the celebrated General SIR RALPH ABERCROMBY, K.B., who commanded the expedition to Egypt, and was mortally wounded at the battle of Alexandria, on the 21st of March, 1801, thus terminating an honorable life with a glorious death in the hour of victory. As a reward for his gallant conduct his widow was created BARONESS ABERCROMBY of Aboukir, and of Tullibody in the county of Clackmannan, by patent dated the 28th of May, 1801.

On the 13th of April, 1782, John Abercromby was appointed cornet in the fifth, the Royal Irish dragoons; and in 1787, when the seventy-fifth regiment was raised by Colonel Robert Abercromby, he was appointed lieutenant in that corps; in 1792 he was promoted captain in the same corps. He served in Flanders under His Royal Highness the Duke of York; and obtained the rank of lieut.-colonel in 1794. In 1795 he was appointed lieut.-colonel in the FIFTY-THIRD regiment, which corps he commanded at the capture of St. Lucia, in 1796, and distinguished himself in the action at the pass of Morne Chabot, for which he was thanked in orders. He commanded the FIFTY-THIRD in the Caribbee war in St. Vincent in 1796,—at the capture of Trinidad, in February, 1797,—and at the unsuccessful attempt on Porto Rico, in April of the same year, under his father, Lieut.-General Sir Ralph Abercromby. In 1800 he was promoted to the rank of colonel, and in 1805

to that of major-general: on the 21st of March, 1807, he was nominated to the colonelcy of the FIFTY-THIRD regiment. He obtained the rank of lieutenant-general in 1812, and was afterwards placed on the staff of the army in India, where he served two years as governor of Madras, and commander-in-chief of the coast army; but in September, 1814, he resigned his appointments to return to Europe for the benefit of his health. He was afterwards honored with the dignity of Knight Grand Cross of the Order of the Bath. Proceeding to Marseilles, in the south of France, for the benefit of his health, he died at that place on the 14th of February, 1817, and was buried with military honors, by the French garrison; the funeral was attended by the French authorities, civil and military, of the department and of the city, and also by the consuls of several nations.

In announcing the death of Lieut.-General the Honorable SIR JOHN ABERCROMBY, G.C.B., in regimental orders, Colonel Sir George Bingham stated,—"The length of time he has served in the FIFTY-THIRD regiment,—his great attachment to the corps,—the interest he took in its welfare, as well as in that of every individual belonging to it, will cause him to be particularly regretted by those not personally acquainted with him; while his high military abilities and upright private character will occasion his loss to be regarded as a calamity to the service."

ROWLAND LORD HILL, G.C.B., G.C.H., K.C.,

Appointed 24th February, 1817.

ROWLAND HILL was appointed ensign in the thirty-eighth foot in 1790; and in 1791 lieutenant in an independent company, from which he was removed to the FIFTY-THIRD regiment, which proceeded to Flanders at the commencement of the French revolutionary war in 1793, and distinguished itself. In the same year he raised an independent company, was promoted to the rank of captain, and appointed to the eighty-sixth regiment, or Shropshire volunteers, then raised by Major-General Cuyler. He accompanied Mr. Drake on a mission to Genoa, and afterwards proceeded to Toulon, where he served as aide-de-camp to the three successive generals commanding there, viz., Lord Mulgrave, Lieut.-General O'Hara, and Sir David Dundas; and was wounded at the attack of the heights of Arenes, on the 30th of November, 1793, and narrowly escaped with his life, when

Lieut.-General O'Hara was taken prisoner. On the evacuation of Toulon, he was sent with despatches to England. In 1794 he was promoted to a majority in the ninetieth regiment, raised at this period by Thomas Graham Esq., (of Balgowan, Perthshire,) afterwards General Lord Lynedoch; and in the same year to a lieut.-colonelcy in that corps. He served at Isle Dieu on the coast of France, at Gibraltar, Malta, and Minorca; on the 1st of January, 1800, he was promoted to the rank of Colonel, and commanded the ninetieth regiment in the expedition to Egypt under General Sir Ralph Abercromby, distinguishing himself during the action on the 13th of March, 1801, when his regiment was at the head of the right column, and repulsed a charge of cavalry with great gallantry. Colonel Hill fell from the blow of a musket-ball on the right temple, and was removed in a state of insensibility, but recovered; the force of the ball having been resisted by a strong brass binding in front of his helmet. On his return to England he was promoted to the rank of brigadier-general, and placed on the staff of Ireland, where he was presented with the freedom of Cork. He was promoted to the rank of major-general, and served in the expedition to Hanover, under Lord Cathcart, in 1805; and in 1808 he embarked from Ireland, with a brigade of infantry, to serve in the Peninsula, where he speedily gave presage of those military virtues which adorned his character. He commanded a brigade at the battles of Roleia, and Vimiera, under Sir Arthur Wellesley; and during the advance into Spain under Sir John Moore, and the corps under his orders covered the embarkation at Corunna. He acquired fresh honors at the passage of the Douro at Oporto, on the 12th of May, 1809, when he commanded the corps which first passed the river, after Lieut.-General Sir E. Paget was wounded: and at the battle of Talavera he again distinguished himself, particularly in repulsing the attack of the French on the hill on the left of the position; he was wounded in the head on this occasion. His services during the whole of the campaigns in the Peninsula and South of France were of a distinguished character, and have called forth the commendations of historians, the praises of Field-Marshal the Duke of Wellington, the thanks of Parliament, the approbation of his Sovereign, and the gratitude of his country. During the early part of 1811, he was absent from the army on account of ill health: but he returned to his post in the month of May with the rank of lieut.-general, and was placed in command of the troops in Estremadura. His abilities were conspicuously displayed in the surprise of a body of French troops at Arroyo dos Molinos, in October,

1811; in the capture of the forts and the destruction of the bridge at Almaraz, in May, 1812; and at the battle of the Nive, on the 13th December, 1813. His reputation was constantly augmented, and his talents, energy, and sound judgment became more conspicuous as the extent of his command was increased, and the nature of his services became difficult. His claim to military eminence was not established by a few solitary acts of courage and skill; but by a career of brilliant service, which will descend to posterity interwoven with the triumphs of the Duke of Wellington, whose victories were followed by the overthrow of the power of Napoleon, and the restoration of the Bourbon dynasty to the throne of France. The services of Lieut.-General Sir Rowland Hill were rewarded with the dignity of BARON HILL OF ALMARAZ, and of Hawkstone in the county of Salop, by patent dated the 17th of May, 1814.

When the return of Bonaparte to France re-kindled the war in Europe, Lieut.-General LORD HILL was selected to hold an important command in the army in Flanders under Field-Marshal the Duke of Wellington; and he was placed at the head of a corps of the allied army at the memorable battle of Waterloo, on the 18th of June, 1815, when the power of Bonaparte was annihilated by British skill and valour, and peace was acquired for Europe. The honorary distinctions conferred upon LORD HILL for his important services, were,—Knight Grand Cross of the Order of the Bath,—Knight Grand Cross of the Royal Hanoverian Guelphic Order,—a medal for the battle of Waterloo,—a cross and three clasps for the battles of Roleia, Vimiera, Corunna, Talavera, Vittoria, Pyrenees, Nivelle, Nive, and Orthes; the Turkish Order of the Crescent,—Grand Cross of the Tower and Sword of Portugal, Commander of Maria Theresa of Austria,—St. George of Russia, and Wilhelm of Holland. He was presented with the freedom of the city of London; and was appointed governor of Hull, and Colonel of the ninety-fourth regiment. In 1817 he was removed to the FIFTY-THIRD regiment.

In 1825 LORD HILL was promoted to the rank of general; and on the 15th of February, 1828, he was appointed General Commanding in Chief, the important duties of which appointment he performed with reputation and advantage to the service fourteen years. He was appointed Colonel of the Royal Regiment of Horse Guards, and Governor of Plymouth, in 1830. His

Lordship's resignation of the command of the Army, in August, 1842, was announced in the following General Order:

"HORSE GUARDS, 15th August, 1842.

"GENERAL LORD HILL finds it necessary to resign the Command of the Army on account of his Lordship's present state of health, and Her Majesty has been graciously pleased to accept his Lordship's resignation.

"When Lord Hill assumed the command which he now resigns, he expressed, in General Orders, his confident hope, that from the General and other Officers, as well as from the Public Departments of the Army, he should receive that support which should enable him to fulfil the important trust reposed in him.

"That hope has not been disappointed, but, on the contrary, realized beyond Lord Hill's most sanguine expectation.

"The conduct of the Troops has, both in the Field and in Quarters, furnished, during Lord Hill's command of them, an example of discipline, regularity, and general efficiency, not to be surpassed, and the Officers have, by their devotion to their duty, enabled his Lordship to maintain the Army in that creditable state. The Officers have, therefore, established their claim to Lord Hill's lasting gratitude and esteem.

"His Lordship cannot, then, but with painful feelings take leave of Officers, Non-Commissioned Officers, and Soldiers, whose conduct has been so uniformly approved by their Sovereign and by their Country.

"These feelings are, however, greatly alleviated and consoled by the reflection that the Command of the Army is now to be resumed by the Duke of Wellington, the ever vigilant and most influential Guardian of its Interests, and whose achievements have raised its character to the highest Pinnacle of Glory."

On the 3rd of September, 1842, Lord Hill was advanced to the dignity of Viscount, by Her Majesty, in consideration of his eminent military services, and in approbation of the ability with which His Lordship had discharged, for a lengthened period, the important duties of General Commanding-in-Chief.

The decease of General Lord Hill occurred on the 10th December, 1842, in the seventy-first year of his age, at Hardwicke Grange, Shrewsbury.

LORD FITZROY JAMES HENRY SOMERSET, G.C.B.,

Appointed 19th November, 1830.

APPENDIX.

MEMOIR OF THE SERVICES OF MAJOR-GENERAL SIR GEORGE R. BINGHAM,
K.C.B.

SIR GEORGE RIDOUT BINGHAM entered the army in June, 1793, as ensign in the sixty-ninth regiment, and served at Corsica and in the Mediterranean. He was promoted to captain in the eighty-first in 1796, and major in the eighty-second in 1801, and he served with those corps at the Cape of Good Hope and the island of Minorca. On the 14th of March, 1805, he was nominated lieut.-colonel in the FIFTY-THIRD regiment, and assuming the command of the second battalion in Ireland, on the 1st of April, he was at the head of that portion of the regiment during the whole of its arduous and distinguished service in the Peninsula, commencing with the expulsion of Marshal Soult's army from Oporto in 1809, and continued until the end of 1812, when the battalion was so reduced in numbers, that six companies returned to England to recruit; and during these campaigns his conduct reflected honour on the corps to which he belonged. In 1813 he commanded with reputation the second provisional battalion. He received a cross and one clasp for the battles of Talavera, Salamanca, Vittoria, Pyrenees, and Nivelle; he was also nominated Knight Commander of the Order of the Bath, and received permission to accept of the Order of the Tower and Sword of Portugal. He commanded the troops which proceeded to St. Helena with Napoleon Bonaparte, in 1815, and served as brigadier-general at that island until 1820, when he returned to England in consequence of having been promoted to the rank of major-general in 1819. In 1831 he was appointed colonel commandant of a battalion of the Rifle Brigade. He served on the staff of Ireland from 1825 to 1832. He died in 1833. As a soldier and a gentleman he stood high in the estimation of all who knew him; he was an ornament to his profession and an honour to his country.

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TRANSCRIBER'S NOTE

Obvious typographical errors and punctuation errors have been corrected after careful comparison with other occurrences within the text and consultation of external sources.

Except for those changes noted below, all misspellings in the text, and inconsistent or archaic usage, have been retained.

[Pg xxxiii](#), 'castle of L'Ourde 5' replaced by 'castle of L'Ourde 52'.

[Pg 3](#), 'towards Ticonderago' replaced by 'towards Ticonderoga'.

[Pg 21](#), Sidenote '1815' inserted at the paragraph 'In 1815 the ...'.

[Pg 55](#), 'occupy the barracks' replaced by 'occupying the barracks'.

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